



CITY: PG 3

Govt to make Delhi child-beggar-free: CM



NATION: PG 4

PM Modi meets CWG medallists, lauds their performances



FILM: PG 12

'Honoured to be a part of Toxic'

Deadlock clouds fate of women's quota, delimitation and FCRA Bills

WITH FOUR DAYS LEFT AND OPPOSITION UNYIELDING, MONSOON SESSION HEADS FOR WASHOUT

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With just four working days left in the Monsoon session of Parliament, uncertainty continues to surround the government's plans to introduce and pass three key pieces of legislation, including the proposed constitutional amendment on women's reservation and delimitation and the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, as repeated disruptions have pushed the session close to a complete washout.

None of the three contentious Bills featured in the Lok Sabha's list of business for Monday, even as the government continued its efforts to build support across party lines. While a few opposition parties have shown signs of softening their position after recent outreach by the Centre, the Congress and most of its INDIA



bloc allies have maintained that they will oppose any attempt to bring the measures before Parliament during the current session.

The proposed Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill seeks to provide 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha from the 2029 general election while also paving the way for a fresh delimitation exercise that would expand the

strength of the Lower House. The legislation suffered a major setback during a special three-day session in April after it failed to secure the constitutionally required two-thirds majority.

The Bill received 298 votes in favour and 230 against, falling well short of the 360 votes needed based on the House's current effective strength. It marked the first time a Bill

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Congress and most INDIA allies oppose the proposed constitutional and FCRA amendments
- » Women's Reservation and Delimitation Bill was defeated in April after missing two-thirds majority

- » FCRA Bill proposes tighter oversight of foreign-funded organisations and asset seizure powers
- » Parliament has witnessed repeated disruptions over the NEET paper leak protests
- » Only the anti-paper leaks Bill has seen detailed debate this session

introduced by the Narendra Modi government had been defeated in Parliament.

Although the National Democratic Alliance's strength in the Lok Sabha has since increased to 299 following the merger of seven Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs with the Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, the ruling alliance still remains significantly short of the numbers required to pass a constitutional amendment. Adding to the uncertainty, three Muslim MPs from the 20-member NCPI have not publicly committed to supporting the NDA.

Despite the arithmetic, there is also a view within political circles that delaying the women's reservation and delimitation Bills until the Winter session would still leave enough time for their implementation

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'They tried to kill me': Mamata after attack on her in Halisahar

Samik Bhattacharya condemns incident; CM calls it 'public outrage'



Mamata Banerjee addresses the media after the attack on her, in Halisahar, on Sunday



The attack on Mamata Banerjee's car in Halisahar, on Sunday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Former Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee was attacked in Halisahar, North 24-Parganas, on Sunday while she was on her way to visit the family of a TMC worker who died in police custody.

According to eyewitnesses, local BJP workers hurled stones, mud, slippers, and bricks at her vehicle and raised "chor" and "dakot rani" slogans.

Reacting to the attack, BJP state president Samik Bhattacharya strongly condemned the incident and said: "The police will take action against such condemnable incidents. She is a former Chief Minister of the state and, moreover, a woman, and she has a certain political stature. We strongly condemn this incident."

Addressing the media outside the deceased's residence,

KEY POINTS

- » Bricks were hurled at my vehicle. If the windows had not been closed, my head could have been smashed. I could have died. We all could have lost our lives'
- » Agnimitra says, 'If BJP workers think they will be praised for such actions, they are wrong. Strict action will be taken against them'
- » Samik says, 'The police will take action...'
- » Suwendu says, 'No intimation was given to the police'
- » Law and order have been deliberately compromised by the ruling BJP, said Arvind Kejriwal



dence, Banerjee alleged that the attack was a planned conspiracy and that the police failed to act despite being present. "Bricks were hurled at my vehicle. If the windows had not been closed, my head

could have been smashed. I could have died. We all could have lost our lives," she said.

Mamata accused the police of remaining "silent spectator" and said she had lost faith in the local police.

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Israel refuses US-backed Gaza peace plan, demands Hamas disarm first

CAIRO: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has rejected US President Donald Trump's 15-point peace plan for Gaza, saying Israeli forces will not withdraw from the territory until Hamas has been fully and verifiably disarmed. The announcement came despite Hamas saying it was prepared to move ahead with the US-backed proposal if Israel also fulfilled its commitments. The latest development has cast fresh uncertainty over efforts to secure a lasting ceasefire and end

Continued on P4

ED Director gets one-year extension

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Centre has extended the tenure of Enforcement Directorate (ED) Director Rahul Navin by one year beyond August 13, according to an order issued by the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) on

This is the first extension granted to the 59-year-old officer

Saturday. The order stated that Navin's tenure has been extended from August 13, 2026, to August

13, 2027. It also allows him to continue in service beyond his scheduled retirement on July 31, 2027, or until further orders, whichever comes earlier. This is the first extension granted to the 59-year-old officer. A 1993 batch Indian Revenue Service officer from the Income Tax cadre, Navin

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Assam flood toll reaches 100 as two more die

MPOST BUREAU

GUWAHATI: Two more people died in Assam's floods over the last 24 hours, pushing this year's flood death toll to 100, according to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA).

The latest victims drowned in floodwaters in Golaghat and Karbi Anglong districts, the ASDMA said in its bulletin on Sunday.

More than 1.37 lakh people continue to face the impact of flooding across seven districts: Charaideo, Darrang, Golaghat, Jorhat, Karbi Anglong, Nagaon and Sivasagar. Golaghat remains the worst-affected district with nearly 70,000 people hit,



followed by Sivasagar with around 40,000 and Jorhat with over 16,000.

The overall situation showed slight improvement from Saturday, when close to 1.5 lakh people in eight districts were affected.

The state administration is running 125 relief camps and relief distribution centres in six districts, providing shelter to

Continued on P4

Over 450 NALSAR students oppose reported invitation to CJ for 2026 convocation

MPOST BUREAU

HYDERABAD: A section of graduating students at the National Academy of Legal Studies and Research (NALSAR) University in Hyderabad has opposed the reported decision to invite Chief Justice of India Surya Kant as the chief guest for the university's 2026 convocation. More than 450 students from the batch of 2026 have signed a representation

Continued on P4

GOVT SAYS 98% DEMANDS MET

J'khand scraps 3 JPSC exams, members resign but students press for CBI probe

MPOST BUREAU

RANCHI: The Jharkhand government on Sunday agreed to cancel three Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) examinations and involve the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in investigating alleged financial irregularities linked to the recruitment process after nearly six hours of talks with protesting students in Ranchi. However, the 16-day-old agi-

TAKEAWAYS

- » ED to probe financial irregularities; CID to investigate criminal aspects
- » Students rejected compromise, demanding a CBI probe into JSSC-CGL
- » Government said 98% of

protesters' demands were accepted

- » Fast-track courts and expert panel approved for recruitment reforms
- » Three JPSC members resigned amid the recruitment scam investigation

tation remained unresolved as student groups refused to

withdraw their protest, insisting on a Central Bureau of

Investigation (CBI) probe into the alleged irregularities in the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission Combined Graduate Level (JSSC-CGL) examination. The developments came amid a major shake-up in the JPSC, with all three serving commission members resigning and their resignations being accepted by Governor Santosh Kumar Gangwar.

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Central Bank of India advertisement featuring a portrait of Sir Sorabji Poehkhanawala and text about the 145th Founder's Day on 09 August 2026.

SEBI advertisement for the SEBICheck app, showing a man holding a smartphone displaying the app interface and a QR code for downloading the app.



20,000 SECURITY PERSONNEL TO GUARD RED FORT

# Facial recognition, fingerprint checks to boost I-Day security

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The Red Fort has been placed under a multi-layered security cover ahead of the Independence Day celebrations, with the Delhi Police deploying advanced technologies, including the Abhigyan app and facial recognition system (FRS) vans to identify suspicious and wanted persons in the crowd, officers said.

The security arrangements have been strengthened amid intelligence inputs. Around 15,000-20,000 Delhi Police and paramilitary personnel are expected to be deployed for the August 15 celebrations. Nearly 25,000 people, including VIPs and VVIPs, are expected to attend the event at the Red Fort.

For the first time as part of the enhanced security arrangements, the Abhigyan application is being used extensively to



screen people in the crowd, the officers said. The application has a database of more than one crore criminals, and police personnel are using handheld devices to collect fingerprints of randomly selected persons, they added. The fingerprint is checked against the database within seconds. A red indication means the person has a criminal record, with details appearing on the screen, while a green indication indicates that no criminal record has been found.

Officials further said that nearly 1,000 CCTV cameras, including facial recognition system-enabled cameras, have been installed to monitor the Red Fort and its surroundings. A high-tech CCTV control room has been set up inside the monument, where police personnel and technical teams are monitoring the area round the clock.

The surveillance network is also being used to keep watch over several kilometres outside the Red Fort, officers

said. Snipers will be positioned at strategic locations, including elevated platforms, while anti-drone systems have been deployed to prevent any unauthorised aerial activity, they added.

FRS vans have also been deployed in the area. Equipped with high-resolution cameras, the vans scan faces in the crowd and match them against available databases. If a wanted or suspicious person is detected, the system generates an alert and sends the information to the control room for immediate verification and necessary action.

Abhigyan and facial recognition technology are strengthening security at the Red Fort, alongside CCTV, fingerprint checks, anti-drone systems and snipers. Kite flying has also been prohibited around the monument.

## JNU cancels permission for event on Umar Khalid's book

**NEW DELHI:** Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) on Sunday cancelled permission for an August 9 discussion on a book authored by former student Umar Khalid, citing "non-disclosure of full facts" about the programme.

The discussion on Fractured Communities: Adivasi Histories and the Politics of Power, organised by the JNU Students' Union (JNUSU), was scheduled at the School of Social Sciences-I auditorium.

The JNUSU termed the cancellation "arbitrary and authoritarian", accusing the administration of suppressing academic discussion and dissent. It said the event would proceed in the open outside the SSS-II building while an alternative venue was being sought.

JNU said the auditorium booking was cancelled by the Dean, School of Social Sciences, after full details of the programme were allegedly not disclosed.

## Man wanted in Delhi rape, POCSO case for 8 yrs nabbed in Pune

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** A man wanted in a rape and POCSO case here for nearly eight years has been arrested from Pune, an officer said on Sunday.

The man, who is 32, allegedly told police during interrogation that he eloped with the victim in 2018 when she was 16 and later got married. The victim, who died in 2024 from TB, had said in an earlier statement to the magistrate that they even have a child from their relationship.

Police said Sagar alias Sumit was apprehended on Thursday from Burde Basti in Pune, following technical surveillance and local intelligence.

"A case of rape with a minor was registered at Anand Parbat police station on February 1, 2018, on the complaint of the mother of the minor girl who had gone missing from her house on January 24 that year,"

a senior police officer said.

During the investigation, the girl was brought back on February 24, 2018, and medically examined. In her statement, she said Sagar was her boyfriend and that she had eloped with him, police said.

She went "missing" again and was found again in September 2020. In her statement recorded under Section 164 of the CrPC, she said she had married Sagar and had a daughter with him.

Police said she later visited her parental home with her daughter in 2023 and was subsequently diagnosed with tuberculosis. She died during treatment in 2024. Her child is currently living with Sagar's grandparents.

Sagar, wanted for nearly eight years, was traced to Pune and arrested on August 6. Brought to Delhi on transit remand, he was sent to judicial custody.

## News at a glance

**AIIMS TRANS-PLANTS KIDNEYS FROM 70-YR-OLD**

**NEW DELHI:** AIIMS New Delhi has successfully performed its second dual kidney transplant using organs from a 70-year-old marginal donor at Command Hospital, Chandimandir. The kidneys were transported from Chandigarh by an Army helicopter despite a 12-hour cold ischemia period. Both kidneys functioned immediately in the 56-year-old recipient, who recovered uneventfully and was discharged within 10 days.

**BA STUDENT DIES BY SUICIDE: COPS**

**NEW DELHI:** A 19-year-old third-year BA student allegedly died by suicide after jumping from a mall near Rajouri Garden's Pink Line Metro Station on August 8. Police recovered a handwritten suicide note and found no initial evidence of foul play. Her family said she had been battling depression since her mother's death in 2021. A case under Section 194 of the BNSS has been registered, and further investigation is underway.

## 17-yr-old shot dead by guard

**GHAZIABAD:** A 17-year-old boy was allegedly shot dead by a security guard at an under-construction building in Sahibabad on Sunday after the guard suspected him of entering the premises to steal, police said.

The deceased, identified as Sameer, a resident of Arthala, had reportedly gone to the Parasnath building to make a reel when security guard Vivek Yadav spotted him inside and allegedly opened fire. The bullet hit Sameer in the abdomen. He was rushed to hospital but died during treatment.

Police detained Yadav and seized the firearm.

## Delhi Police honours personnel for valour

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

**NEW DELHI:** Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar felicitated 14 police personnel for displaying exceptional valour, devotion and sacrifice in the line of duty. Personnel from various wings were recognised for their exemplary performance and commitment to ensuring public safety.

During the event, the Commissioner lauded their fearlessness, professionalism and dedication, saying their

conduct reflected the highest standards of public service and helped strengthen public trust and confidence in the police. The personnel were recognised for going above and beyond their duties in challenging circumstances to protect citizens and maintain the well-being of society. The felicitation recognised exemplary service and aimed to inspire police personnel to uphold valour, devotion and community service while strengthening trust and ties with the public.

## GARHMUKTESHWAR TO OLD DELHI ‘Cycle Kanwar Yatra’ by Delhi Police, IRS officers promotes peace, social harmony

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

**NEW DELHI:** Senior Delhi Police and Indian Revenue Service (IRS) officers on Sunday took part in a cycle Kanwar Yatra from Garhmukteshwar in Uttar Pradesh to the historic Shri Gauri Shankar Temple near the Red Fort, conveying a message of peace, social harmony and public service.

The yatra, organised on August 9, began at Garhmuk-

teshwar, a major pilgrimage centre on the banks of the Ganga, and concluded at the temple in the heart of Old Delhi with Jalabhishek.

Delhi Police personnel Vipul Anekant and Sandeep

Lamba, along with IRS officer Mukesh Rathore, participated in the yatra. The officials are expected to seek blessings for peace and harmony in society and strength to serve the people.

The initiative aimed to reach out to citizens through the police, IRS and other government departments, using the Kanwar Yatra as a platform to promote social cohesion, harmony and public service.

The cycle yatra formed part of wider efforts to engage with the Kanwar pilgrimage, which is undertaken by thousands of devotees across the country every year. While many Kanwariyas trek to Gangotri and Badrinath to collect water from the Ganga and offer it at Shiva temples, the Delhi Police and IRS officers participated in the pilgrimage on bicycles, carrying the message of peace and harmony.

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RULES ON PAPER?

# Kanwar boomboxes, Delhi asked to listen

Residents flag jams, blaring music & mounting garbage

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: As Delhi prepares for the peak days of the annual Kanwar Yatra, residents living along the designated pilgrimage corridors say the festivities have already begun affecting their daily lives, with long traffic jams, blaring music from procession vehicles and mounting garbage becoming common in several neighbourhoods.

The first large groups of Kanwariyas entered the Capital over the weekend, while the heaviest movement is expected between August 9 and 11. To ensure smooth conduct of the yatra, authorities have deployed over 15,000 police personnel and nearly 2,000 traffic officials across the city. However, people residing along the routes say civic inconvenience has increased significantly in the past few days.

Eight major Kanwar routes pass through busy stretches such as Ring Road, Mathura Road, Wazirabad Road, GT Road, Rohtak Road and Najafgarh Road, disrupting regular traffic movement. From August 9 to August 12, the GT Road stretch between Apsara Border and Yamuna Bridge will remain closed to general traffic, with commuters advised to use alternate routes.

Residents say the diversions have lengthened travel time, affecting office-goers, students and those dependent on public transport.

“Even a short journey now takes almost twice as long. Traffic remains at a standstill whenever a convoy of Kanwariyas passes, and reaching work on time has become extremely difficult,” said Ritu Sharma, a resident of Inderlok.

A resident of New Friends Colony, Aditya Verma, said roads leading to South Delhi witness severe bottlenecks during the evening hours. “Ambulances, school buses and office traffic all get caught in the same congestion. We respect the pilgrimage, but better traffic management is necessary so that ordinary commuters are not stranded for hours,” he said.

Apart from congestion, residents have raised concerns over loud music played from heavily decorated trucks carrying pilgrims. Many of these vehicles are fitted with oversized speakers



REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

‘The sound is so intense that windows and doors keep vibrating’

ers that continue playing devotional songs at high volume even when stationary.

According to a recent news report by *Hindustan Times*, recorded noise levels exceeded the CPCB’s 55-decibel residential daytime limit, despite laws capping loudspeakers at 75 decibels and restricting their use under noise and motor vehicle regulations.

“The sound is so intense that windows and doors keep vibrating. The noise continues late into the night, making it impossible for children, elderly people and patients to rest,” said Sana Ali, who lives near Govind Puri.

Residents of Okhla also claimed that repeated complaints about excessive noise have yielded little relief. “We have contacted the authorities several times, but the loud music continues every night. Devotion should not come at the cost of disturbing entire neighbourhoods,” said Sarita Singh, a local resident.

Another concern emerging from areas hosting Kanwar camps is the growing accumulation of waste. Residents of Govind Puri and Okhla said disposable plates, plastic bottles, food packaging and other litter often remain scattered around pandals after meals are served.

“Community kitchens are feeding thousands of devotees, which is commendable, but

the waste generated is enormous. Garbage piles up on roadsides and vacant plots if it is not cleared promptly, creating foul smells and attracting stray animals,” said Meena Gupta, a resident of Govind Puri.

People living near several camps also pointed to overflowing dustbins and blocked drains, urging civic agencies to increase the frequency of waste collection during the yatra.

Delhi Police said personnel have intervened in some cases by asking drivers to lower the volume of their sound systems, though no formal cases have been registered so far.

The Delhi Traffic Police has established 306 traffic regulation points and made arrangements around 308 Kanwar camps across the city. Around 644 traffic personnel have been deployed in East Delhi alone, where a large number of pilgrims are entering from Uttar Pradesh.

Traffic officials said personnel have been instructed to regulate vehicle movement and guide commuters towards alternative routes wherever required.

On Saturday, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited a Kanwar Seva Camp near the Delhi-Uttar Pradesh border at Dilshad Garden to review arrangements for food, drinking water, sanitation and medical assistance. With the yatra expected to witness its highest footfall over the coming days, residents say they hope authorities strike a balance between facilitating the religious event and addressing concerns related to traffic, noise pollution and sanitation so that daily life in the city remains manageable.

## Delhi plans buses to 18 Bihar destinations

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has begun the process of establishing direct inter-state bus connectivity with Bihar by proposing a reciprocal transport agreement that would allow regular stage carriage services between the national capital and 18 destinations across the neighbouring state.

Officials said the transport department has been asked to prepare a draft agreement with the Bihar government to improve public transport options for the large number of commuters travelling between the two states. The proposal envisions an equal allocation of permits, with each state allowed to operate 12 buses on the identified routes.

Under the proposed network, four routes have been planned between Delhi and Patna, while two routes each

are proposed for Gaya and Muzaffarpur. The remaining destinations include Darbhanga, Bhagalpur, Purnea, Araria, Kishanganj, Bihar Sharif, Buxar, Madhubani, East Champaran and Nawada, among others.

According to officials, “passenger demand between Delhi and Bihar remains consistently high because a significant population from Bihar lives and works in the capital. Travel volumes increase sharply during major festivals, making additional public transport services necessary.” The proposed Delhi-Kishanganj route, spanning nearly 1,416 km, would be the longest under the agreement. Services to Purnea and Araria would cover approximately 1,390 km and 1,348 km, respectively. Depending on the alignment, buses travelling between Delhi and Patna would operate over distances ranging from around 1,045 km to 1,182 km.

## PROMOTES ROAD SAFETY, WASTE SEGREGATION

# MCD holds Raahgiri Day in Karol Bagh

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) organised a Raahgiri Day event in Karol Bagh on Sunday to promote road safety, cleanliness and waste segregation among residents.

The event was held at DLF Midtown Plaza on Shivaji Maharaj Marg in the Karampura Industrial Area, Moti

Nagar, under the guidance of Central Zone Deputy Commissioner Dilkhush Meena. It was organised in collaboration with the Raahgiri Foundation and the Commission for Air Quality Management. More than 300 people, including around 100-150 school students, participated in the event. Activities such as cycling, fitness exercises, interactive games and awareness programmes were organised

to encourage public participation. The programme focused on road safety, cleanliness and responsible waste management under the Swachh Bharat Mission. Participants were encouraged to segregate waste at source and adopt responsible disposal practices to help maintain cleaner public spaces.

The MCD also highlighted the role of citizen participation in improving the city’s cleanliness

# Govt to make Delhi child-beggar-free: CM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi government will soon launch a ‘Child Beggar-Free Delhi’ campaign to protect children found begging at public places and major road intersections in the city, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has said.

In a video posted on X on Saturday, Gupta said the campaign will be conducted across 13 districts of the capital to provide a secure future to children forced into beggary.

The children will not be moved by force, instead the government, along with the



Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights (DCPCR) and NGOs, will counsel their families, address their difficul-

ties and provide better alternatives, Gupta said.

“The campaign will also identify and expose organised gangs forcing children into begging,” she said, asking people to provide their comments and suggestions on the campaign.

DCPCR Chairman O P Vyas said that after considering the feedback from the public, the campaign is expected to be launched around Independence Day. There are two aspects to the child beggar issue, he said.

“First, we will focus on parents and ensure their counselling so that children are weaned

away from begging. The other is the involvement of organised gangs who force small, homeless and poor children into begging, which will require strict legal action,” Vyas said.

Besides NGOs, child welfare committees will also be actively engaged in the campaign, he said.

Under the Juvenile Justice Act, child welfare committees have been empowered to take decisions with regard to the children in need of care and protection, Vyas said.

Children freed from beggary require care and protection,

for which they will be empowered through education and skill training, he said.

The DCPCR will ensure that after being freed from beggary, the smaller children are provided formal education while the older ones are empowered through skill training, he added.

According to estimates by social organisations, there are around 70,000 street children in the capital, of which thousands are engaged in begging at public places, including around religious sites, bus and Metro stations, market places and major road intersections.

## CM: Next-gen lawyers to strengthen justice tradition

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday said the country’s long-standing tradition of justice, rooted in constitutional values and reason, would be further strengthened by the next generation of legal professionals. She was addressing students at the valedictory ceremony of the first National Trial Advocacy Competition organised at National Law University (NLU), Delhi, with the support of Think India.

Interacting with participants, faculty members and young law students, the Chief Minister highlighted the importance of nurturing skilled legal professionals who can contribute to a more accessible,

transparent and efficient justice delivery system. Speaking at the event, Gupta said India’s judicial tradition has always placed the highest importance on fairness, constitutional principles and rational thought. She expressed confidence that the energy and talent of young advocates, coupled with modern judicial infrastructure, would help shape a stronger legal system for the future. The CM said the Delhi government is working towards strengthening the Capital’s judicial ecosystem by supporting initiatives aimed at improving infrastructure and creating an environment that meets the evolving needs of the justice system.

MPST

# Delhi L-G asks govt to rotate long-serving officials

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has been directed by L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu to formulate a policy for systematic rotation of officials and to transfer those holding same posts for longer duration, officials said on Sunday.

The directions were issued by the L-G in a recent review

of systems, processes and practices prevalent for over a decade, in a meeting with principal secretary (vigilance) of the Delhi government.

He also instructed that the list of sensitive departments be reframed, after learning that while some departments with higher financial allocation were not included in the list of sensitive departments, others

seemingly less sensitive ones were included in it, according to officials.

Further, Sandhu also directed that chief vigilance officers (CVOs) be immediately posted at all the sensitive departments for ensuring transparency and financial probity, officials said.

The standard mechanism and operational guidelines

need to be devised for CVOs, detailing how they should supervise the adherence to the Chief Vigilance Commission (CVC) guidelines in contracts and tender processes, the L-G said.

The vigilance department was asked to undertake regular meetings of departmental CVOs to review vigilance work, officials added.



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\* (Among companies with revenue scale of more than ₹15,000 million) in India in terms of revenue, growing at a CAGR of 31.26% from Fiscal 2024 to Fiscal 2026. (Source: 1Lattice Report) | # As of March 31, 2026

MILKY MIST DAIRY FOOD LIMITED is proposing, subject to applicable statutory and regulatory requirements, receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP with RoC, SEBI and the Stock Exchanges on August 4, 2026. The RHP shall be available on the website of SEBI at [www.sebi.gov.in](http://www.sebi.gov.in), and is available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE and NSE at [www.bseindia.com](http://www.bseindia.com) and [www.nseindia.com](http://www.nseindia.com), respectively, on the website of the Company at [www.milkmist.com](http://www.milkmist.com) and the websites of the BRLMs, i.e., JM Financial Limited, Axis Capital Limited and IIFL Capital Services Limited (formerly known as IIFL Securities Limited) at [www.jmfl.com](http://www.jmfl.com), <https://www.axiscapital.co.in/> and [www.iiflcapital.com](http://www.iiflcapital.com), respectively. Any potential investors should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see “Risk Factors” beginning on page 23 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP and should instead rely on their own examination of our Company and the Offer, including the risks involved, for making any investment decision. The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the U.S. Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the “U.S. Securities Act”) or any state securities laws in the United States and, unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States, except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, such Equity Shares are being offered and sold (i) outside of the United States in offshore transactions in reliance on Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales occur; and (ii) within the United States to “qualified institutional buyers” (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act), pursuant to the private placement exemption set out in Section 4(a) of the U.S. Securities Act. The Equity Shares have not been and will not be registered, listed or otherwise qualified in any other jurisdiction outside India and may not be offered or sold, and Bids may not be made by persons in any such jurisdiction, except in compliance with the applicable laws of such jurisdiction. There will be no public offering in the United States.



LAUDS THEIR PERFORMANCES

# PM Modi meets CWG medallists

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday met members of the Indian contingent that returned with medals from the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow and congratulated the athletes for their impressive performances at the multi-sport event.

Modi shared a short video clip of his interaction with the medallists on Instagram, describing the meeting as a special occasion and praising the athletes for making the country proud.

Later, the PM also tweeted about his meeting with the athletes.

“Delighted to host our outstanding medal winners from the Commonwealth Games 2026 at 7, Lok Kalyan Marg. Heard about their experiences from the Games. Each one of them has made our nation proud through their exceptional performances. Their success will motivate many youngsters,” Modi posted on



PM Narendra Modi with athletes from India's Glasgow 2026 Commonwealth Games contingent, alongside IOA President PT Usha, Union Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, during a felicitation ceremony at the Prime Minister's residence, in New Delhi

X while sharing some photographs of the meeting.

Sports minister Mansukh Mandaviya was also present.

Among those who interacted with the Prime Minister was boxer Sakshi Chaudhary, who won the gold medal in the women's 51kg category at the

Games. India enjoyed a strong campaign in Glasgow, finishing with 39 medals, including 13 gold.

Sakshi said: “Our honourable PM sir has welcomed all the medallists from the Commonwealth Games and we are feeling very proud of this. We

have really enjoyed meeting him, he is very humble.”

Modi, while interacting with the athletes, said: “Jo khelega, woh khiega. Always cheer for Bharat.”

The Prime Minister spoke to the medallists and congratulated them for their efforts.

## Highlights

» Modi shared a short video clip of his interaction with the medallists on Instagram, describing the meeting as a special occasion and praising the athletes for making the country proud

» India's boxing contingent enjoyed a particularly successful campaign, with the country's pugilists winning a record haul of 10 medals at the Glasgow Games

India's boxing contingent enjoyed a particularly successful campaign, with the country's pugilists winning a record haul of 10 medals at the Glasgow Games.

Sakshi was among the seven Indian boxers who returned with gold.

## BJP claims CJP is AAP's 'pet project'

Slams Kejriwal for crude 'remarks' on Modi in viral video

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The BJP on Sunday alleged that the CJP's protest at Jantar Mantar was the “pet project” of AAP to target Prime Minister Narendra Modi as it attacked former Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal for his alleged crude remarks in a video circulated online.

BJP IT department head Amit Malviya claimed on X that the protest had nothing to do with education reforms or the NEET paper leak issue.

Malviya also posted the video where Kejriwal can be heard purportedly saying in Hindi, “Is baar jitne log aaye the saddon par, wo kis liye aaye the? Wo kewal mujhe nahin lagta ki Dharmendra Pradhan ka istifa mangne aaye rahe. Matlab agar main crude bhasha mein boloon, to Modi ji ko thokne aaye the. (The people who took to the streets this time, what did they come for? I don't think they came merely to demand Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. To use crude language, they came to take on Modi ji).”

News agency could not independently verify the authenticity of the video footage. There was no immediate reaction from the AAP or Kejriwal to the BJP's charge.

Several BJP leaders, including former president of the party's Delhi unit Virendra Sachdeva, condemned the AAP leader for his alleged remark on Modi. In a post on X, the BJP Jammu and Kashmir unit said, “Kejriwal has finally exposed his pet project -- the Cockroach Janta Party. The agenda was never accountability or education reform. From day one, it was about one thing: targeting PM Modi.”

Malviya alleged that the former Delhi chief minister has admitted that the protest at Jantar Mantar, ostensibly held in the name of students, was a sponsored political project aimed at targeting the prime minister and had nothing to do with education reforms or the NEET.

It was always evident that Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke and “his gang” had deep links with

the AAP, Malviya said.

“But after the protest, the cockroaches went rogue, stopped taking Arvind's calls and forced the insecure Kejriwal to spill the beans on the true motive behind the protests,” he claimed.

“Your children were used as cannon fodder for the AAP and Congress's political agenda. Never forget that. They could have been hurt, embroiled in violence, or had their lives ruined. But that didn't happen, thanks to the exemplary restraint shown by the law-enforcement agencies,” the BJP leader added.

Malviya also called for exposing those who pretended to lead the protest but abandoned it at the right time to save themselves and their sponsors, “like Rahul Gandhi and Arvind Kejriwal.”

BJP Rajya Sabha MP Swati Maliwal slammed Kejriwal for his remarks and claimed that students were peacefully protesting for their issues till Kejriwal decided to “hijack the movement and turn it into a political opportunity.”

## From Page 1

### FCRA Bills

before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections.

The proposed FCRA Amendment Bill has emerged as another flashpoint between the government and the opposition. The legislation seeks to tighten oversight of organisations receiving foreign funding and proposes the creation of a new authority with powers to seize and manage the assets of non-profit organisations whose licences are cancelled. The proposal has drawn criticism from several Christian organisations as well as opposition parties.

Congress general secretary KC Venugopal warned that his party would strongly resist any attempt to introduce the legislation during the remaining days of the session.

“If the central government thinks they can cook up and introduce the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill within these two or three days, they should keep that wish to themselves,” Venugopal said in Alappuzha on Sunday. He alleged that the proposed law targets minorities and non-governmental organisations and described it as unconstitutional.

“Even if Amit Shah comes to pass this anti-people Bill, there is no doubt that he will have to face strong protests in Parliament. This Bill is unconstitutional and anti-people. We will not allow such an anti-people and unconstitutional Bill to be passed,” he said.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh also cautioned against a repeat of the 2023 Winter Session, when 146 opposition MPs were suspended and several important laws were passed with minimal opposition present in the House. He said “history should not repeat itself.”

The Monsoon session, which began on July 20, has been dominated by protests from opposition parties, resulting in repeated adjournments and very little legislative business. The Opposition initially raised the NEET paper leak issue and allegations regarding theft of donations at the Ayodhya Ram temple. It later shifted focus to demanding a statement from Home Minister Amit Shah on the police action against students protesting over the NEET paper leak. Opposition parties have also sought statements from Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Shah in Parliament. So far, the only major legislation to receive detailed discussion in both Houses has been the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, aimed at curbing paper leaks. Apart from that, three more Bills have been cleared by both Houses with little or no debate, while two additional Bills have been passed by the Lok Sabha amid continued disruptions.

In an effort to break the deadlock, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju held two meetings with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi last week and also spoke to him over the telephone. According to sources, Rijiju sought Congress support for the women's reservation and delimitation Bills, but Gandhi insisted that the government first convene an all-party meeting to discuss the proposed legislation. The two leaders also exchanged remarks on social media over the issue on Saturday.

The government has also been

reaching out to other opposition parties. However, responses have remained mixed.

DMK leader Udhayanidhi Stalin said on Friday that his party had opposed delimitation in the past and would continue to do so. The DMK, which is no longer part of the INDIA bloc after the Congress joined the TVK government in Tamil Nadu, now has 22 Lok Sabha MPs, making it the third largest opposition party in the Lower House. In the Rajya Sabha, its eight members make it the second largest opposition party. DMK president MK Stalin has separately urged the Centre to withdraw the proposed FCRA Amendment Bill. He said a delegation led by party MP P Wilson had recently met Home Minister Amit Shah to press for its withdrawal.

Meanwhile, the Shiromani Akali Dal extended support to both the Women's Reservation Bill and the delimitation proposal, provided the increase in Lok Sabha seats is uniformly applied across all states by 50 per cent. The announcement came a day after party chief Sukhbir Singh Badal met Prime Minister Modi, prompting speculation over a possible return of the Punjab-based party to the NDA before next year's Assembly elections. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay also convened a meeting of a section of the state's MPs on Saturday, where a resolution opposing delimitation was adopted. The resolution demanded that the number of Lok Sabha seats remain frozen at 543. The meeting was boycotted by both the DMK and the AIADMK.

NCP (SP) working president Supriya Sule said it would be premature to comment on the delimitation Bill before its introduction. “When it comes, we will discuss every Bill with our alliance partners,” she said. However, she opposed the FCRA Amendment Bill in its present form, saying foreign funding should not always be viewed with suspicion and urging the government to either withdraw the legislation or refer it to a Joint Parliamentary Committee.

Sule also announced that a delegation of eight NCP (SP) MPs would meet the prime minister in Parliament on Monday. Following her remarks, the Congress urged her to clearly convey the INDIA bloc's opposition to linking the implementation of women's reservation with delimitation.

The Congress has issued a three-day whip directing its MPs in both Houses to remain present on August 10, 11 and 12, saying very important issues would come up for discussion. It has also asked its INDIA bloc partners to ensure full attendance during the final days of the session. For Monday, however, the Lok Sabha agenda includes only four Bills: the Tribal Reforms Bill, 2026, the Minerals and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, the Kerala (Alteration of Name) Bill, 2026, and the National Co-operative Development Corporation (Amendment) Bill, 2026, with no indication that the contentious constitutional amendment or FCRA legislation will be taken up immediately.

## ‘They tried to kill me’

Banerjee held the state's Home minister responsible for the deteriorating law and order situation in Bengal and alleged “the incident

reflected administrative failure.”

Responding to the allegations, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari denied any BJP connection with the incident and called it a “public outrage.” He added: “The DG Security informed me that no intimidation was given to the police. She went without informing the police. From the visuals I have seen, I did not notice any BJP leader or flag.”

In a social media post, the TMC said that Suwendu Adhikari's denial was false and alleged that the attack had been carried out under the instructions of Bijpur MLA Sudipta Das. The party also shared photographs supporting its claim, which showed that Halisahar Ward 8 BJP leader Arindam Dey and BJP ST Morcha state secretary Anand Besra were among the attackers.

The incident took place when the TMC supremo went to the residence of the deceased, Birju Keot. Halisahar police arrested 48-year-old Keot, who was the husband of former Kanchrapara municipal councillor Jenny Sharma Keot, on Friday on charges of extortion, financial fraud, and offences under the Arms Act. He was produced before the Barrackpore court, which remanded him to five days in police custody. According to police, Keot fell ill suddenly inside the lockup early on Saturday and was taken to Jawaharlar Nehru Memorial Hospital in Kalyani, where doctors declared him dead. His wife claimed that he was completely fine a day before his death and that it was caused by severe physical torture and assault in custody. Keot's brother also claimed that injury marks were visible on his body and that he had bleeding from his ears. Police have ordered an investigation into the allegations.

TMC MP Kalyan Banerjee, who accompanied the former Chief Minister on Sunday, alleged that the victim's family was being threatened not to have a conversation with Mamata Banerjee. He also identified one of the attackers and said he was “Ananda Besra, a friend of the local MLA.”

TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee described the incident as evidence of a “complete collapse of law and order” under the BJP government. He alleged that Mamata Banerjee had been “brutally attacked by goons planted by the BJP” and said the government had failed to protect political workers, prevent custodial deaths, or ensure the safety of a former chief minister. Senior TMC leader Kunal Ghosh also targeted the BJP and the state administration, alleging that the attack was politically motivated and that the police had failed to discharge their responsibilities.

Aam Aadmi Party leader Arvind Kejriwal also condemned the incident and wrote in an X post: “Law and order have been deliberately compromised by the ruling BJP to threaten and attack opposition leaders in West Bengal. The desperation in the BJP keeps growing as the Modi government loses popularity.” State Urban Development minister Agnimitra Paul also cautioned against the incident. She said: “If BJP workers think they will be praised for such actions, they are wrong. Strict action will be taken against them.”

## ED Director

has headed the federal anti-money laundering agency since September 2023. He was first given additional charge as ED chief on

September 15, 2023, before being appointed full-time Director on August 14, 2024. Under existing rules, an ED Director is appointed for an initial term of two years, with the provision of up to three one-year extensions.

Navin joined the ED in November 2019 as Special Director (OSD), where he led the agency's work related to India's mutual evaluation by the Financial Action Task Force (FATF), the global watchdog against money laundering.

During his tenure, the ED has pursued several major investigations, including cases involving political consultancy firm I-PAC, the Reliance Anil Ambani Group and multiple online money gaming companies. The agency has also taken action in real estate fraud cases, using powers under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) to restore assets worth crores of rupees to affected homebuyers. It has also moved to reduce long-pending litigation by processing cases under the repealed Foreign Exchange Regulation Act (FERA) and initiating compounding proceedings under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA).

Originally from Bihar, Navin has spent three decades in the Income Tax Department, particularly in international taxation. An IIT Kanpur graduate with B.Tech and M.Tech degrees, and an MBA from Swinburne University of Technology in Melbourne, he has also written books, journals and articles on international taxation and transfer pricing.

## Israel refuses

the war that has displaced nearly 1.9 million people, or about 90 per cent of Gaza's population, according to the United Nations.

Addressing a cabinet meeting on Sunday, Netanyahu said, “Israel rejects the 15-point document. The IDF will not carry out any withdrawal until Hamas is genuinely disarmed and will continue to thwart threats against our forces and our citizens.” He also said Israel was discussing the next steps with US officials, adding that while some American proposals were acceptable, others were not.

Trump's Board of Peace announced last month that an agreement had been reached for the complete disarmament of Hamas and other armed groups in Gaza. The plan, unveiled in September last year, proposes the creation of a Board of Peace to oversee implementation, the phased disarmament of Hamas, the withdrawal of Israeli troops and the reconstruction of Gaza.

Hamas, however, has maintained that handing over its heavy weapons depends on Israel ending “all forms of aggression” and withdrawing its forces from Gaza. A Hamas official said the group remained committed to the agreement and was ready to “engage seriously and responsibly” in implementing the plan. Another official said Hamas and other Palestinian factions had informed mediators that they were prepared to begin the second phase of the agreement once Israel approved it and started implementing its commitments.

Netanyahu's rejection comes amid domestic political pressure, with members of his right-wing coalition urging a tougher stand on Gaza. National Security Minister Itamar Ben Gvir has described the

proposed agreement as “not acceptable” and called for a fresh cabinet vote on the issue.

The latest disagreement follows criticism of Israel's military campaign by the United Arab Emirates and seven other Muslim-majority nations, which issued a joint declaration warning that continued military operations could undermine the US-backed peace initiative.

The war began after the Hamas-led attack on southern Israel on October 7, 2023, in which about 1,200 people were killed and 251 were taken hostage. Israel's subsequent military offensive in Gaza has killed more than 73,000 people, according to the territory's health ministry, figures that the United Nations considers reliable. AGENCIES

## Assam flood

49,061 displaced people. During the past day, authorities distributed 710.44 quintals of rice, 127.85 quintals of dal, 38.34 quintals of salt and 3,773.7 litres of mustard oil among affected families.

According to the ASDMA, floodwaters continue to submerge 456 villages and have damaged 11,933.46 hectares of cropland. Embankments, roads, bridges and other public infrastructure have also suffered damage in several districts.

The Dhansiri river at Golaghat and Numaligarh, and the Kushiyara river at Sribhum, were flowing above the danger level. Flooding has also affected 43,331 domestic animals and poultry across the state.

## NALSAR

urging the Vice Chancellor, Registrar, faculty members and other university authorities to reconsider the proposal.

In their letter, the students referred to recent judicial proceedings linked to alleged police action during the Parliament march protest from Delhi's Jantar Mantar on July 20, 2026. They cited a July 23 hearing in which the CJI reportedly declined to watch video evidence of the alleged police excesses, saying, “We are not interested in videos; we don't have time to watch.” The representation also alleged that the petitioner's counsel was prevented from fully presenting submissions.

The students further referred to another petition seeking an enquiry into the alleged police action, claiming that more than 70 protesters, including women and children, were injured. They also objected to remarks attributed to the Chief Justice, including his reported comparison of Indian youth to cockroaches.

“Our concern is narrow and more specific to us as a graduating batch,” the letter said, adding that a convocation should reflect NALSAR's commitment to constitutional rights, access to justice and reasoned engagement with grievances. The students argued that receiving degrees from a dignitary whose recent reported conduct appeared dismissive of allegations of police brutality would not align with those values.

The signatories requested the administration to reconsider the invitation, consult the graduating batch before making a final decision and respond by Monday. They also offered to discuss the issue through meetings or other appropriate chan-

nels. NALSAR has not issued an official response.

The development comes weeks after the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS), Mumbai, postponed its August 2 convocation less than two days before the event. CJI Surya Kant had been expected to attend as chief guest. While TISS cited “unforeseen circumstances”, officials and students familiar with the matter said there were concerns that possible protests linked to the Cockroach Janta Party movement could disrupt the ceremony. India Today could not independently verify whether those concerns directly led to the postponement. The delay also disappointed several graduating students who had already arranged travel and accommodation for their families. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

## J'khand scraps 3 JPSC exams

Separate meetings were held with delegations from the JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch, JPSC-JSSC Abhyarthi Nyay Manch and representatives associated with AISA at the state guest house in Ranchi. The latest discussions marked the sixth round of negotiations between the government and the protesting students.

Following the talks, the government agreed to cancel the JPSC Backlog 2023 examination, JPSC Backlog 2025 examination and the preliminary examination of the 14th JPSC Combined Civil Services. It also agreed that the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) would investigate criminal aspects of the alleged irregularities, while the ED would examine financial and economic offences related to the recruitment process.

Student leader Ravindra Paswan said the government had accepted most of the demands but the protesters would continue their agitation until their demand for a CBI inquiry was met.

“Most of our demands have been met, including the demand for cancellation of the 14th JPSC exam. But we will not compromise till our demand for a CBI probe is fulfilled. We will continue our proposed march to the Jharkhand Assembly on August 10,” he said.

The government, however, maintained that it could not accept the demand for a CBI investigation into the JSSC-CGL examination because it had been conducted under the monitoring of the High Court and the Supreme Court.

Technical and Higher Education Minister Sudivya Kumar Sonu said the government had accepted 98 per cent of the students' demands.

“We held positive dialogue with students. The Jharkhand government will recommend an ED probe into financial irregularities in the JPSC exam. Now they will take a final call whether to withdraw the agitation or not,” he said.

The minister announced that a fast-track court would be set up to ensure charge sheets are filed within 90 days in cases related to recruitment examination irregularities. He also said a panel comprising experts from IIT-ISM Dhanbad, IIM Ranchi and XLRI Jamshedpur would recommend reforms in the examination system. Student representatives said institutions such as IIMs and XISS would also be consulted for broader reforms in the functioning of the JPSC and JSSC.

On the JSSC-CGL issue, the government proposed a high-level

judicial inquiry headed by a retired High Court judge, with the ED examining financial aspects and the CID probing criminal allegations. Student groups, however, continued to demand cancellation of the examination, claiming they had submitted evidence of a paper leak. They also sought a CBI investigation into all recruitment examinations, publication of the probe report, action against those responsible, revocation of the suspension of whistleblower Santosh Kumar Mastana and withdrawal of cases registered against him.

Mastana, a finance department section officer, was arrested by the CID in October 2025 for allegedly spreading a “fake narrative” about a paper leak in the JSSC-CGL examination conducted in September 2024. He was later granted bail by the Jharkhand High Court.

The talks took place as six protesters continued an indefinite hunger strike.

Earlier in the day, Chief Minister Hemant Soren assured protesting youths that justice would be delivered transparently and appealed for dialogue instead of confrontation.

“Samvad and not ‘lathi-danda-bandook’ can solve all problems. Weapons are meant for enemies at the border. I promise the exam protesters that justice will be delivered with full transparency,” Soren said while addressing the Jharkhand Adivasi Mahotsav.

He alleged that vested interests were attempting to disrupt democracy in the state and warned against politicising the students' movement. Referring to the handling of protests over the NEET paper leak, Soren said young people elsewhere had faced baton charges and pellet guns, and urged Jharkhand's youth to bring their concerns directly to the government instead of seeking political patronage. He added that those found responsible for examination irregularities would face strict action.

Governor Santosh Kumar Gangwar also appealed to the students to resolve the issue through dialogue, saying the government's doors remained open.

Meanwhile, the three JPSC members, Ajeeta Bhattacharya, Anima Hansda and Jamal Ahmad, resigned after being summoned by the CID for questioning over alleged irregularities, including paper leaks. Bhattacharya is scheduled to appear before investigators on August 10, Ahmad on August 12 and Hansda on August 14.

The resignations came weeks after JPSC chairperson L Khandge stepped down on July 22, saying he wanted to ensure an impartial investigation. Khandge, who has been questioned four times by the CID since July 28, resigned a day before investigators searched multiple locations, including his official residence. So far, 19 people have been arrested in connection with the alleged recruitment scam.

Investigators have also arrested Abhay Tiwari alias Manoj Kumar Tiwari, a Block Supply Officer in Godda District. The CID alleges he played a key role in the recruitment racket while simultaneously serving as marketing manager of TSR Data Processing Private Limited, the private agency associated with conducting the examinations. Student representatives said the government agreed to investigate all examinations linked to Tiwari and the company, although it stopped short of cancelling every examination conducted by the agency.



'NO ONE MISLED GEN Z, THAT'S BJP'S HABIT'

# Attempts to ‘mislead’ Gen Z led to my resignation: Pradhan; Oppn hits back

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**BHUBANESWAR:** Senior BJP leader and Sambalpur MP Dharmendra Pradhan said attempts were made to “mislead” Gen Z during the protests over the NEET paper leak issue, prompting him to quit as Union education minister.

Pradhan broke his silence on his resignation while addressing students and teachers at GM University here on Saturday, exactly two weeks after he stepped down amid massive protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi over the issue.

“Gen Z is our children. Some people attempted to mislead them. I had no personal issues then. At least two crore children are born in India every year. During the last 10 years, 20 crore children were born. They have aspirations, and they will make India the ‘Vishwa Guru.’ The post was not impor-



Dharmendra Pradhan

tant to me,” Pradhan said.

He said he had approached Prime Minister Narendra Modi and offered to resign from the Union Council of Ministers.

Pradhan resigned from the ministry on July 25.

At another meeting in Raikhol, Pradhan hit out at former Odisha chief minister and BJD president Naveen Patnaik, saying he was not disturbed by

protests by BJD workers and slogans asking him to “go back”.

Meanwhile, the Opposition on Sunday lashed out at former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan for his remark that attempts were made to ‘mislead’ Gen Z during the protests over the NEET paper leak issue, saying the students were raising valid concerns and that it is actually the BJP that has a

Highlights

» Pradhan said he had approached PM Modi and offered to resign from the Union Council of Ministers

» - It is unclear whether he had the ambition to remain a minister or was instructed by Modi or Shah, said Kharge

“habit” of misleading people.

Senior BJP leader and Sambalpur MP Pradhan claimed that efforts were made to mislead Gen Z during the protests, which led to his resignation as Union education minister.

Reacting to Pradhan’s remarks, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge told a news agency in Rudrapur, “It is unclear whether he had the ambition to remain a minister or was instructed by Prime

Minister Narendra Modi or Home minister Amit Shah. What students recognise is that he was responsible since he held that position.”

Kharge added, “The home minister has the CBI, the Intelligence Bureau, and all the agencies at his disposal, so he should investigate the matter.”

Aam Aadmi Party’s Sanjay Singh also criticised Pradhan for his comments, stating, “Did the paper leak occur or not? Twenty-one students have lost their lives. There is no question of students being misled.”

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Arvind Sawant claimed that misleading people is the BJP’s tactic.

Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut also hit out at Pradhan and stated that Gen Z’s reactions were provoked by how Pradhan managed education issues, including the paper leaks.

## You will have to answer for this crime: Rahul to Amit Shah

Over police brutalities against protesting students

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Closer Look

» Instead of apologising, Modiji is busy dispensing ‘forgiveness’, Gandhi said

» Gandhi asserted that students are the light of the nation, and said he stands with them with all his might

**NEW DELHI:** Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday questioned Home Minister Amit Shah’s silence over alleged police brutalities against protesting students and asserted that sooner or later, the BJP leader would have to answer for “this crime”.

Gandhi said a student told him during his “Chhatron ki Goonj” event in Prayagraj on Saturday that he has “no options left now”.

“This is exactly what a student told me in Prayagraj yesterday. Years of preparation, selling the family land, parents burdened with debt and yet, nothing to show for it,” Gandhi said in a post in Hindi on X.

This is not his failure, it is the failure of a system that refused to reward his hard work, the leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha added. Several days have passed since the students protesting at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar over alleged paper leaks have called off their agitation, yet not a sin-

gle word has come from Shah on the action taken by the Delhi Police against them, he said.

“Instead of apologising, Modiji is busy dispensing ‘forgiveness’, Gandhi said.

“Amit Shahji, do not think for a moment that we will stop demanding accountability. Batons and pellets were used against young people on the streets of the capital -- and you did not utter a single word. Sooner or later, you will have to answer for this crime,” he said.

Gandhi asserted that students are the light of the nation, and said he stands with them with all his might.

Both Houses of Parliament remain deadlocked over the Opposition’s demand that Shah should make a statement in both Houses on the alleged police brutalities during the students’ July 20 protest over the paper-leak issue.

Most of the legislative business has been conducted amid din. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge slammed Shah last week for not making a statement in Parliament over the alleged police brutalities on students and said the home minister did not come to the Rajya Sabha despite Chairman C P Radhakrishnan noting that he should speak in the House.

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju told the Lok Sabha on Friday that the Opposition cannot dictate which minister will come to the House and respond to their questions, amid the demand from the Congress and other parties that Shah should give answers to queries on the recent police action on protesting students.

UP CM LEADS TRICOLOUR MARCH IN LUCKNOW

## Kakori was an act of resistance, not dacoity: Yogi

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

**LUCKNOW:** Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday led a Tricolour march in Lucknow to mark the 101st anniversary of the Kakori Train Action, with thousands of people joining the procession from his official residence to the state Assembly.

The march began at around 9.20 am from 5, Kalidas Marg and reached the Vidhan Bhawan after covering nearly two kilometres in about 30 minutes. Adityanath walked with Deputy Chief Ministers Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak and state BJP president Pankaj Chaudhary.

The procession was accompanied by patriotic songs, chants of “Vande Mataram” and “Bharat



CM Yogi Adityanath during the ‘Tiranga Yatra’, in Lucknow

Mata Ki Jai”. Around 30,000 people, including Cabinet ministers, BJP leaders, schoolchildren and young people, took part in the march. A group of children car-

ried a 101-foot-long Tricolour to the Assembly.

Adityanath also interacted with children during the march and took selfies with them and Chaudhary.

UP Women Commission vice-chairperson Aparna Yadav and BJP state vice-president Pooja Pal were among those who participated. Yadav said the participation of Gen-Z showed that young people were connected with the country’s patriotic traditions.

Speaking at the Kakori Train Action centenary programme, Adityanath said the revolutionaries involved in the incident had a single objective, to free India from British rule.

“Kakori was not a dacoity. The sole objective of our great revolutionaries was to secure

India’s freedom and drive the British out,” he said.

The British administration had described the incident as a dacoity, but Adityanath said it was unfortunate that the same description continued to be used after Independence. He credited Prime Minister Narendra Modi with giving the incident its historical identity by referring to it as the Kakori Train Action.

The Kakori Train Action took place on August 9, 1925, near Kakori in Lucknow. Hindustan Republican Association revolutionaries stopped a train carrying govt treasury money and seized the funds to support their armed struggle against British rule. The incident became one of the defining episodes of the revolutionary movement in northern India.

## PM urges people to participate in ‘Har Ghar Tiranga’ campaign

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday urged people to enthusiastically participate in the ‘Har Ghar Tiranga’ campaign and said India’s national flag is the country’s pride and a constant source of inspiration to always give the best for the nation.

The ‘Har Ghar Tiranga’ campaign, which began in 2022 under ‘Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav’, has become an annual national tradition, with crores of citizens voluntarily hoisting the national flag every Independence Day.

“Our Tricolour is our pride and a constant source of inspiration to always give our best for the nation. Let us participate enthusiastically in the #HarGharTiranga movement and renew our collective resolve to contribute towards building a Viksit Bharat,” Modi said in a post on X’.

The prime minister said he was glad that this year’s efforts are dedicated to national song ‘Vande Mataram’ and that too at a time when the nation is marking its 150th anniversary.

The 2026 edition of the ‘Har Ghar Tiranga’ campaign was launched on August 6 and will be observed across the country from August 9 to 17.

## FCRA Bill will be resisted in Parliament, says KC Venugopal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**ALAPPUZHA:** AICC general secretary KC Venugopal on Sunday said the Congress and other Opposition parties would strongly protest the proposed FCRA Bill if the Centre introduced it in Parliament.

He also asked Union Home minister Amit Shah to answer questions on the use of force against students during protests against the NEET paper leak.

Speaking to reporters, Alappuzha MP accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Shah of avoiding questions and not appearing in Parliament due to fear of facing them.

“If the Central government thinks they can cook up and introduce the Foreign Contri-

bution (Regulation) Amendment Bill within these two or three days, they should keep that wish to themselves,” he said.

Venugopal alleged that the proposed legislation targeted minorities and NGOs and said the Opposition would not allow it to be passed.

He said that when students in India ask the crucial question of who ordered the use of pellet guns, lathi charges and tear gas shells against them to suppress their protest, Amit Shah would not come forward to answer it.

“Even if Amit Shah comes to pass this anti-people Bill, there is no doubt that he will have to face strong protests in Parliament. This Bill is uncon-

stitutional and anti-people. We will not allow such an anti-people and unconstitutional Bill to be passed,” Venugopal said.

He also questioned the alleged foreign funding received by organisations associated with the RSS while objecting to proposed restrictions on NGOs receiving funds under the FCRA.

“If you have the courage, try controlling the RSS,” he said, alleging that organisations operating lawfully under the FCRA would be targeted by the proposed legislation.

On the proposed delimitation Bill, Venugopal said it would adversely affect states that had successfully implemented population-control measures.

## Raj: School students turn journalists to counter lack of newspapers in village

An innovative approach to education

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**JAIPUR:** Addressing the lack of access to newspapers in rural areas, a government school in Rajasthan’s Tonk has started publishing its own newspaper, giving students a platform to develop creativity, journalism skills and leadership abilities.

In an innovative approach to education, PM Shri Government Senior Secondary School, Raholi, publishes ‘Raholi Shiksha Samachar’ in Hindi and ‘Raholi Education Times’ in English, both in print and online, with students from Classes 10 to 12 handling almost every aspect from its production to publication.

Speaking to news agency, School Principal Yogendra Singh Naruka said, covering academic, cultural, sports, social, environmental and innovation-related activities held at the school, students undertake news gathering, photography, videography, interviews, news writing, editing, graphic designing and page layout themselves.

While some students work as photographers, others take on roles such as reporters, news writers, graphic designers and editorial assistants.

Teachers act as guides and mentors throughout the process.

An editorial board has been constituted to oversee the newspaper’s operations. It includes Principal Yogendra Singh Naruka, teacher Pooja Patidar and selected students. The board familiarises students with the nuances of journalism and ensures the quality of the content.

Naruka, who has studied journalism, told news agency that after taking charge at the school in Raholi, a rural and relatively remote area, he noticed that very few students received newspapers at home.

Key Points

- » While some students work as photographers, others take on roles such as reporters, news writers, graphic designers and editorial assistants
- » Teachers act as guides and mentors throughout the process
- » An editorial board has been constituted to oversee the newspaper’s operations

He also observed that many innovative activities and achievements of the school did not receive adequate coverage in major newspapers.

“Whenever news about any achievement of the school, along with a photograph, was published, students would read it repeatedly, show it to their classmates and become extremely excited. This experience led to the idea of publishing a newspaper of our own,” he said.

Naruka said the school first published a book based on its three-year development plan in the 2022 academic session. Following the success of that effort, the first issue of ‘Raholi Shiksha Samachar’ was published in 2023 using his own funds.

“After that, our teacher colleagues extended their support for the regular publication of the newspaper, and the initiative gradually developed into a strong educational innovation,” he said.

The print edition is published monthly, quarterly or on special occasions, depending on the availability of funds and time, Naruka said.

He said the initiative does not receive any separate financial assistance from the government.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

**PUDUCHERRY:** Union Home minister Amit Shah on Sunday presented President’s Colours to Puducherry Police in appreciation of the valour, dedication and service rendered by the force in the Union Territory.

Lt Governor K Kailashnathan and Chief Minister N Rangasamy were among the officials present on the occasion.

While addressing the gathering, Shah said presenting the President’s Colours to a police force is indeed one of the most prestigious occasions for him.



He said the force has earned this honour due to the hard

work, valour, service and dedication displayed by it.

“It is a matter of pride that Puducherry represents the very essence of spiritual and cultural ethos of south India. It continues to live up to its status as a French colony by retaining its Indian and spiritual values even after being governed by the French for a long time,” said Shah.

He further said that the post of Director General of Police (DGP) was created on October 1, 1963, in Puducherry. Since then, police have contributed immensely to the internal security of the Union Territory.

The Home minister said that criminal laws of India are undergoing a ‘revolution’ with the introduction of three new criminal laws.

“New criminal law replaces the criminal law ordinance of the British Raj and aims to bring speedy justice through technology and trust. The entire gamut of crime fighting mechanism will be guided by the principles of Technology, Timeline and Trust,” he added.

Shah informed that development works worth Rs 2,200 crore are underway for the four-laning of National Highway 332-A in Puducherry.

“The development of an extended runway of 3,400 metre and 45 metre in width also commenced,” he said.

According to Shah, an amount of Rs 3,500 crore has been released to the Union Territory for development works between 1950 and 2014.

Further, Rs 13,762 crore has been released to Puducherry in the tenure of Prime Minister Narendra Modi till 2026, which is almost four times higher than the previous allocation.

“Industrial investment of around Rs 39,000 crore has been made in the past nine years in the Union Territory,” he added.

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\*Source: CRISIL Report | \*\* As of March 31, 2026



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This pictorial representation of map of India does not purport to be the political map of India. Map not to scale.

**DHOOT TRANSMISSION LIMITED**, is proposing, subject to applicable statutory and regulatory requirements, receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offering of its Equity Shares and has filed the RHP dated August 3, 2026 with the RoC. The RHP and Abridged Prospectus shall be available on the website of SEBI at [www.sebi.gov.in](http://www.sebi.gov.in), as well as on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE and NSE at [www.bseindia.com](http://www.bseindia.com) and [www.nseindia.com](http://www.nseindia.com), respectively, on the website of the Company at [www.dhoottransmission.com](http://www.dhoottransmission.com) and on the websites of the BRLMs, i.e. Axis Capital Limited, Jefferies India Private Limited, Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited, Nomura Financial Advisory and Securities (India) Private Limited, SBI Capital Markets Limited and 360 ONE WAM Limited at [www.axiscapital.co.in](http://www.axiscapital.co.in), [www.jefferies.com](http://www.jefferies.com), <http://investmentbank.kotak.com>, <http://www.nomuraholdings.com/company/group/asia/india/index.html>, [www.sbicap.com](http://www.sbicap.com) and [www.360.one](http://www.360.one), respectively. Any potential Bidders should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risk, see ‘Risk Factors’ on page 24 of the RHP. Potential Bidders should not rely on the UDRHP-I filed with SEBI and the Stock Exchanges for making any investment decision and should instead rely on the RHP, when filed, for making an investment decision.

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INDIA'S MESSAGE TO THE WORLD

# Op Sindoor showed we will go to any extent for citizens' safety: Rajnath

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Operation Sindoor demonstrated the unmatched valour of the country's armed forces, who sent a global message that India will go to any extent to ensure the safety of its citizens, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Sunday.

He was addressing an event held at the Base Hospital, Delhi Cantonment.

Singh commended the defence forces for eliminating terrorists and their handlers based in Pakistan and ensuring that those who dared to cast an evil eye on India faced dire consequences.

Indian armed forces conducted Operation Sindoor in May 2025 in response to the deadly Pahalgam terror attack.

"Operation Sindoor demonstrated the unmatched valour of our defence forces who sent a global message that India will go to any extent to ensure the safety of its citizens while protecting the sindoor worn by our women," Singh said at the blood donation camp, titled 'Sindoor Maharaktadan Yatra', at the Base Hospital. Drawing a parallel with the mega blood donation camp, Singh asserted that it represents compassion while Operation Sindoor showcased courage.

Approximately 1,000 wrestlers and athletes from Maharashtra were among the donors who participated in the camp, demonstrating the spirit of selfless service and solidarity with the armed forces, the defence ministry said in a statement.

Expressing gratitude to the donors, the Union minister expressed confidence that the blood donated today would



Defence minister Rajnath Singh during the 'Sindoor Maha Raktadan Yatra' at Base Hospital in New Delhi

## HIGHLIGHTS

» Singh commended the defence forces for eliminating terrorists and their handlers based in Pakistan

» Indian armed forces conducted Operation Sindoor in May 2025 in response to the deadly Pahalgam terror attack

serve as a credible reserve for needy soldiers and their families in the future.

He described blood donation as 'jivandan' and 'mahadan', stressing that despite remarkable advances in science and medicine, no artificial substitute for human blood has yet been developed.

Since (human) blood can only be produced by the human body and donated by one person to another, Singh said, blood donation remains "one of the noblest forms" of charity. He underlined that every blood donor and recipient is, in their own way, serving the nation, and urged the people,

particularly the youth, to make blood donation a culture. "When we celebrate 100 years of our independence in 2047, our aim should not be limited to a developed economy; we must also envision a compassionate society where people are healthy and safe, and precious resources like blood are readily available in times of need," Singh said.

The event was attended by Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde, Minister of State for Ayush (Independent Charge) Pratap Rao Jadhav, Maharashtra Minister of Industries Uday Ravindra Samant, MP Srikant Eknath Shinde, Chief of the Army Staff Gen Dhiraj Seth, DG Armed Forces Medical Services (AFMS) Surgeon Vice Admiral Arti Sarin and other senior military and civil dignitaries, the statement said.

For AFMS, maintaining adequate blood reserves assumes particular significance as military hospitals cater to routine healthcare requirements as well as operational, trauma and emergency contingencies.

BIOMEDICAL WASTE MANAGEMENT RULES

# Violations in 'deep burial' of medical waste by 17 states, UTs: CPCB to NGT

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) has informed the National Green Tribunal that it will take action against states and Union territories not complying with some rules for disposal of biomedical waste.

The green body is hearing a matter regarding violations in the handling, treatment and disposal of biomedical waste by treatment facilities.

In an order dated August 5, a bench of NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert member Afroz Ahmad noted that CPCB had filed a report (dated August 5) regarding the "deep burial" of biomedical waste which was practised across 17 states and Union territories in the country. Deep burial remains a limited disposal method under

## INSIGHT

» The green body is hearing a matter regarding violations in the handling, treatment and disposal of biomedical waste by treatment facilities

» Deep burial remains a limited disposal method,



permissible only in rural or remote regions where a Common Bio-Medical Waste Treatment Facility is unavailable

the Biomedical Waste Management Rules, permissible only in rural or remote regions where a Common Bio-Medical Waste Treatment Facility is unavailable. Such practice requires prior approval of the prescribed state authority.

The tribunal noted that out of 9,178 Healthcare Facilities (HCFs) using deep burial, only 5,715 were compliant with standard provisions, with the most

frequent violations including failure to maintain a minimum groundwater table level of six metres below the burial pit (477 HCFs non-compliant) and operating without proper authorisation from prescribed authorities (341 HCFs).

It noted that the report showed significant gaps in compliance across various parameters by the states and UT's concerned. For instance, in

Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan, all 111 and 33 HCFs, respectively, were found non-compliant.

The tribunal said, "Counsel appearing for the CPCB has informed that presently the communications have been sent to the concerned State Pollution Control Boards (PCBs)/ Pollution Control Committees (PCCs) of the violating states and UTs and, if the compliance is not done within eight weeks, then the directions under Section 5 of the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986 will be issued." The provision grants the Centre enforcement powers to issue binding directives, including to regulate or shut down industrial operations and terminate utility services.

The tribunal directed the CPCB to file a further progress report at least one week before the next date of hearing on October 28, 2026.

# Why SAD desperate for BJP alliance, asks Cong

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Congress president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring Sunday asked why SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal was so "desperate" for an electoral alliance with the BJP that he had to make a "U-turn" on a sensitive matter like delimitation of the assembly and parliamentary constituencies.

The remark came a day after the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) demanded that Parliament pass the women's reservation bill and the delimitation bill with a uniform 50 per cent increase in seats for states so that they are implemented without further delay.

The Badal-led party announced its revised stand on the delimitation issue after its president's meeting with

Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Delhi on Friday left political circles abuzz with talk of a patch-up with the BJP.

Warring recalled and reminded Sukhbir that in April, the SAD had strongly opposed the delimitation bill and described it as "against the interests of Punjab".

"So, what changed within these three months that you started seeing merit in the same bill that you otherwise found against Punjab's interests," he asked.

The Ludhiana MP noted that the reasons are obvious that Badal, who is "desperate" for his political survival, is trying to woo the BJP so that it agrees for an electoral alliance ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections in the state. MPOST

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday laid the foundation stone of a centre dedicated to the study of life, philosophy and words of Sri Guru Ravidas at Dera Sachkhand Ballan in Jalandhar.

Sri Guru Ravidas Ji Bani Adhyayan Centre will come up over 10.4 acres at an overall cost of Rs 37 crore, including Rs 11 crore for the land. The Punjab government will bear the cost of construction, according to an official statement.

Mann laid the foundation stone in the presence of Dera Sachkhand Ballan Niranjan Dass. The centre will have a three-storey administration and teaching block, boys' and girls' hostels with accommodation for 54 students each, and a

## The centre in Jalandhar will be dedicated to study of life & philosophy of Guru Ravidas

two-storey building for teachers and staff.

It will provide children, students and research scholars a dedicated space to study the life, Bani, philosophy and teachings of Guru Ravidas and undertake research that carries the light of his wisdom and message across the world, it said. The foundation stone has been laid as part of the Punjab government's year-long celebrations of the 650th 'Parkash Purab' of Guru Ravidas, for

which Rs 100 crore has been earmarked.

As part of these celebrations, 50 mobile vans are travelling across all 23 districts to screen documentaries on his life, philosophy and teachings in 13,000 villages, taking his message of equality, humanity and dignity to people across Punjab, the statement said.

Mann said this centre will go a long way in undertaking extensive "adhyayan" (study) of Guru Ravidas's words, besides being instrumental in propagating his teachings in every nook and corner of the world. "I hope that this centre will act as a lighthouse for further perpetuating the ideology of Sri Guru Ravidas so that our future generations can seek inspiration from his Bani." MPOST

# Mathura: Sadhus announce 'kar seva' on Dec 6

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

## The choice of Dec 6 is significant as it is the anniv of the demolition of the disputed structure in Ayodhya in 1992

Sachchidanand said after the meeting.

The choice of December 6 is significant as it is the anniversary of the demolition of the disputed structure in Ayodhya in 1992 by kar sevaks.

A large number of sadhus attended Sunday's programme and expressed their support for the proposed campaign for the construction of a grand Krishna temple at the birthplace of Lord Krishna.

The announcement comes days after the first consignment of pink sandstone ordered for the proposed temple reached

Mathura late on Friday. The stones have been brought from Banshi Paharpur in Bharatpur, Rajasthan, the same source of sandstone used in the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

Sachchidanand said an order had been placed for around 5,000 metric tonnes of pink sandstone for the proposed Krishna temple. He said the second consignment of stones had currently been put on hold. The Chitragupt Peeth had earlier announced that sadhus from all 13 akharas would be invited for the programme to formally announce the kar seva.

The police and district administration have been monitoring the activities closely following the announcement. Notices have been issued to several prominent religious figures, including Sadhvi Ritambhara, storyteller Devkinandan Thakur, Mahant Phoolad

Bihari Das Maharaj, Shri Charandas Maharaj, Saurabh Gaur, Sitaram Das Maharaj, Sant Abhishek Brahmachari, Mohini Bihari Sharan Maharaj and Mahamandaleshwar Krishnanand Maharaj.

The notices caution the recipients against activities around the Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi site that could disturb communal harmony and public order.

Police have alleged that videos and posters related to kar seva were being circulated on social media in a manner that could provoke people under the cover of religious sentiments. The notices ask the religious leaders to refrain from activities at or around the Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi site that could affect communal peace.

The police have also warned that legal action would be initiated if any activity was found to threaten public order.

# Training aircraft suffers 'runway excursion' at Baramati

NEW DELHI: A Cessna C172 training aircraft operated by DGCA-approved Flying Training Organisation Academy of Carver Aviation suffered a runway excursion at Baramati Airfield in Maharashtra on Sunday. No injuries or casualties were reported in the incident.

The incident involving aircraft VT-SEX occurred around 12:25 pm while the aircraft was being used for Circuit and Landing Emergencies (CLEM) training.

The aircraft was flown by Flight Instructor Captain Chirag Shashikant Doifode, with trainee Abhijeet Jundre on board. According to initial reports, the aircraft taxied out at 12:09 pm (0639 UTC) for the training exercise.

During the session, the aircraft was instructed to enter the runway through Link Bravo and align at the threshold of Runway 29 for a rejected take-off exercise. It was subsequently instructed to line up at the threshold of Runway 11 for another rejected take-off exercise. While carrying out the manoeuvre, the aircraft reportedly veered off the runway after it could not stop within the paved portion. It went beyond the extended paved surface past the threshold of Runway 29 and came to a stop on the right side. The safety of both the instructor and trainee was confirmed, and there were no casualties.

The aircraft has prima facie suffered damage to its propeller, engine cowl and nose landing gear. The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) is expected to assess the extent of the damage as part of its preliminary examination.

The DGCA's Air Safety team is also travelling to the site to conduct a preliminary inquiry into the incident.

The investigation is expected to examine the training procedure, aircraft performance, runway condition and other relevant factors to determine the cause of the runway excursion. MPOST

# Modern labs to boost research & innovation among students: Saini

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said modern laboratories for science, computers and robotics would create new avenues for experimentation, research and innovation for students.

Addressing the inauguration of new educational facilities at O P Jindal Modern School in Hisar, Saini said such facilities would help prepare students for the needs of the 21st century.

He inaugurated the 'Utkarsh' Administrative Block, 'Uday' SEN Wing, 'Udgam' Swimming Pool and 'Utsav' Auditorium on the school premises.

The ceremony marked the 96th birth anniversary of former minister, industrialist and philanthropist O P Jindal. Saini congratulated the school management and teachers on



CM Nayab Saini inaugurates new facilities at OP Jindal Modern School

the new facilities and said the institution's modern methods, technology and approach were preparing students for the present era.

He said the Innovation Hub at the school was a commendable initiative that would provide children an environment to express their ideas, develop them into models and projects, and work with peers and

teachers to find solutions to problems.

Saini said educational institutions such as the school would play an important role in preparing the younger generation for the requirements of the 21st century and contribute to the implementation of the National Education Policy and the building of a "Viksit Bharat-Viksit Haryana". MPOST

SHOWCASING RICH CRAFTS, TRADITIONS & CULTURAL HERITAGE

# I-Day's At Home: 50 artists from once LWE-hit Chhattisgarh behind 'handmade' invitation kit

NEW DELHI: Nearly 50 artists from once Naxal-affected Chhattisgarh are part of a team of 130 artisans, who have created this year's handmade invitation kit for Independence Day At Home, hosted by President Droupadi Murmu.

The invitation kit showcases the rich crafts, traditions, and cultural heritage of Chhattisgarh, Goa, Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh. Officials from the Rashtrapati Bhavan and a team from the National Institute of Design (NID), Ahmedabad, conceptualised it in alignment with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals, reflecting India's commitment to sustainability, inclusivity, and cultural preservation.

"The invitation kit was created by around 130 people, including nearly 50 artisans from the once Left-Wing Extremism-affected Bastar region of Chhattisgarh, highlighting the transformative impact of inclusive development and livelihood opportunities," said Ashok Mondal, Director, NID.

## KEY POINTS

» The Independence Day At Home is hosted by President Murmu

» The invitation kit was created by a team of around 130 people

» Officials from the Rashtrapati Bhavan and a team from the NID, Ahmedabad, conceptualised it



» The kit stands as a symbol of India's artistic excellence and sustainable practices

He said over more than three months, these artisans, along with NID faculty members, designers and students, employed their traditional, eco-friendly craft practices to design this unique invitation kit to be sent on behalf of the President of India.

"The kit, which is completely handmade and eco-friendly, stands as a symbol of India's artistic excellence, sustainable practices, and the empowerment of traditional artisan communities," Mondal said. The invitation showcases inspiring examples

of sustainable environmental practices and conservation initiatives from Chhattisgarh, Goa, Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh - a region blessed with a rich landscape of rugged hills, winding river systems and abundant greenery.

Using the vibrant living art traditions of these states, the invitation offers a glimpse into the deep interdependence between communities, creativity and conservation. Mondal said the invitation package showcases Dhokra casting (one of India's oldest metal-casting traditions) from Chhattisgarh,

representing the community's practice of sacred grove protection and the wrought iron Pitwa craft, which contributes to the display frame and bell.

The NID director said that mirroring the daily life and culture of local tribes, this eco-friendly art form transforms recycled scrap iron into striking, minimalist sculptures and objects of daily use. Each piece is hand-forged from a single rod or sheet of metal without casting. The wrought iron bell attached to the address slip is also handcrafted by skilled tribal ironsmiths in Bastar, using recycled scrap iron.

The Azulejo tile painting on the invitation depicts Goa's Khazan lands, which are community-managed coastal wetlands, reclaimed from mangrove forests and marshes.

Developed centuries ago, this ancient agro-aqua ecosystem uses an intricate network of dykes (bunds), embankments and sluice gates to control tidal river water, preventing saltwater from flooding crops while supporting paddy cultivation, fishing, and salt-pan-

ning, Mondal said.

The Khazan ecosystem is essentially a nature-based coastal defence system. The Warli painting on the kit highlights the restoration of the Kham River in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Maharashtra, which is a collaborative effort between local institutions, environmental organisations, and community participants to renew the relationship between people and their natural environment.

Through waste management, water treatment, native species plantation, and revitalisation of shared public spaces, the river corridor gradually transformed into a more resilient ecological landscape, he said. Mondal said the Bhil artwork on the invitation showcases community-led seed preservation practices in Madhya Pradesh which continue to safeguard indigenous varieties of grains, pulses, and vegetables adapted to local climates and food systems. Bhil painting is a vibrant tribal art form from Madhya Pradesh, typically created using neem twigs. PFI

# Truck-car collision leaves six dead in MP

MPOST BUREAU

DHAR (MP): Six persons were killed after a container truck collided with their car in Madhya Pradesh's Dhar district on Sunday afternoon, police said.

The accident occurred around 1.30 pm near Pan-chak Vasa, around 4 km from Badnawar town, an official said.

Additional Superintendent of Police Parul Belapurkar said a container coming from Ujjain crashed into a car, killing all six of its occupants on the spot.

The victims were residents of Gujarat, she said, adding that the driver of the container truck has been taken into custody.

Further investigations are underway, the official said.

# Nation Briefs

## NFR TO OBSERVE 'HAR GHAR TIRANGA' CAMPAIGN FROM AUG 9 TO 17

MALIGAON: Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) will observe the 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign from August 9 to August 17, 2026, in line with the initiative of the government



to encourage citizens to hoist the National Flag at their homes and foster a personal and emotional connection with the Tiranga. The campaign was launched by the government in 2022 under the aegis of 'Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav'. Every year, NFR observes the 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign with great enthusiasm, promoting the spirit of patriotism and encouraging active public participation, officials said on Sunday.

## BIHAR: SEIZED TRUCK GOES MISSING FROM POLICE STATION, PROBE ORDERED

MUNGER: A seized truck loaded with stone chips went missing from the premises of Mufassil police station in Bihar's Munger district. The truck was seized by the district mining officials last month and handed over to the police station. Munger SP Imran Masood said: "It is a serious incident and a high-level inquiry has been constituted to probe the matter." Strict action will be taken against those found involved, he added.



EDITORIAL  
CHANGING  
OF GUARD

India's aviation sector has entered an unusual moment of leadership transition. Its two most consequential full-service aviation stories are now being entrusted to two globally experienced executives, but the assignments could hardly be more different. William "Willie" Walsh has taken charge of IndiGo after completing his tenure as Director General of the International Air Transport Association, while Tewolde Gebremariam, the former Ethiopian Airlines chief, has been appointed CEO and Managing Director of Air India. Walsh brings experience from British Airways and International Airlines Group; Gebremariam is credited with transforming Ethiopian Airlines into Africa's dominant carrier. Both appointments therefore carry considerable weight. Yet one man inherits an airline that has established overwhelming scale and now wants to become more global, while the other inherits an airline still trying to repair its foundations.

For Walsh, the task at IndiGo is less about rescue than reinvention. IndiGo has built its success around a remarkably clear proposition: low fares, high aircraft utilisation, operational discipline and an enormous domestic network. But scale creates its own complications. The airline is moving beyond the model that made it successful, expanding internationally and positioning itself for a larger share of long-haul traffic. Walsh must ensure that ambition does not dilute the simplicity and efficiency that have been IndiGo's greatest strengths. He also arrives after a period of operational disruption and the departure of Pieter Elbers, circumstances that underline the importance of reliability even for a market leader. As IndiGo grows larger and more complex, the danger is that it begins accumulating the costs and complications of a global network carrier without acquiring the service standards, systems and resilience required of one. Walsh's experience in managing large international aviation businesses should be valuable here. His challenge is essentially to change IndiGo without damaging what already works.

Gebremariam faces almost the reverse problem. Air India possesses many of the ingredients IndiGo is seeking: a globally recognised name, valuable international routes, long-haul operations and the backing of the Tata Group. What it still lacks is consistency. The transformation initiated after Tata regained control in 2022 has included new aircraft orders, a brand overhaul, cabin upgrades and the integration of Vistara, but the process remains unfinished. Gebremariam arrives following a devastating Boeing 787 crash in 2025, heightened regulatory scrutiny and continuing questions over safety and compliance. The airline also reported losses exceeding \$2 billion in 2025-26, while geopolitical disruptions, including restrictions affecting regional airspace, have added to operating pressures. These are not cosmetic problems that can be addressed through a new logo, new seats or an advertising campaign. Air India needs operational discipline to become institutional rather than episodic. Passengers must be able to expect the same standards across aircraft, airports, crews and routes. Above everything else, safety, engineering, maintenance and regulatory compliance must command unquestioned priority.

Gebremariam's record offers reason for optimism, but Air India will test even an accomplished turnaround specialist. During his long tenure at Ethiopian Airlines, the carrier expanded dramatically, with revenue multiplying and its fleet growing substantially while Addis Ababa developed into a major connecting hub. India offers a vastly larger home market and an enormous diaspora, yet a significant proportion of international traffic originating in India continues to travel through foreign hubs. Air India's great opportunity is to capture more of that traffic directly through Indian gateways. But geography, aircraft availability, product consistency, intense competition from Gulf and Southeast Asian airlines and the costs imposed by geopolitical disruptions complicate that ambition. Gebremariam therefore cannot simply reproduce the Ethiopian model in India. He must adapt his experience to a far larger, more competitive and more demanding aviation ecosystem. The Tata Group, meanwhile, will have to give him the authority and time required to impose difficult operational discipline. Turnarounds of airlines as complex as Air India are measured in years, not quarters.

The contrasting assignments ultimately illustrate where Indian aviation itself stands. IndiGo represents the success of a disciplined private airline that must now prove it can translate domestic dominance into international relevance. Air India represents the unfinished revival of a historic flag carrier that must first restore consistency and confidence before its global ambitions can be fully realised. Walsh must guard against complacency while pursuing sophistication; Gebremariam must replace inherited complexity with reliability while pursuing recovery. Their successes would not merely strengthen two companies. India is becoming one of the world's most important aviation markets, and its airlines need to capture a larger share of the international traffic generated by its own economy and population. For IndiGo, the next frontier is becoming global without losing its operational DNA. For Air India, it is becoming dependable before becoming formidable. Two new CEOs have therefore taken the controls at very different altitudes. How well they navigate their respective challenges could determine the shape of Indian aviation for the next decade.

TALKING  
SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER  
IS A VETERAN  
JOURNALIST AND  
COMMUNICATIONS  
SPECIALIST

No road can be called 'world-class' just because it was inaugurated quickly. The real test comes when such infrastructure built using public money remains safe, sound and usable years after the politicians and cameras have left

STRATEGIC  
ARC



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS  
A RETIRED IPS  
OFFICER, ADVISER  
NATSTRAT, AND A  
FORMER NATIONAL  
SECURITY ADVISOR  
IN MAURITIUS

India is already Australia's fifth-largest trading partner, with two-way trade in goods valued at over \$24 billion in 2025-26

Road Today, Gone Tomorrow

India is building highways at staggering speed and cost, but many are cracking or sinking soon after they open. That begs a question: What are we paying for?

"The rise and decline of any State are better measured by the condition of its roads than by any other criterion."  
— Hilaire Belloc

There is something absurd about driving on a brand-new expressway, paying a toll for the privilege and finding yourself dodging potholes, cracks and sunken patches even before the road has earned the right to settle respectfully in public memory. Dang it, this would be almost funny if it weren't potentially fatal too. Yes, India is building expressways at a breathtaking pace. New ones are being announced, inaugurated and thrown open with impressive statistics: kilometres completed, thousands of crores invested, travel time saved, wildlife corridors constructed, advanced traffic-management systems installed.

The infrastructure story is one of national ambition. But there is another story emerging from beneath the asphalt. How long are these roads supposed to last? And who is responsible when they don't survive even for a blink? Such questions have acquired urgency with the Delhi-Dehradun Economic Corridor. This 213-km six-lane corridor inaugurated in April at a cost of Rs 12,000 crore was designed to cut the journey from more than six hours to two-and-a-half. Within days, images of a massive pothole on the new road began circulating. In July, another section suffered a cave-in after heavy rain.

The National Highways Authority of India says the July incident resulted from localised water stagnation and difficulties in commissioning a permanent cross-drainage system at the location. The affected portion was repaired. Parliament has also been told that potholes were detected and repaired under the project's 10-year defect-liability period.

Fine. Let us accept the explanation. But then let us ask an uncomfortable question. Why was a brand-new, Rs 12,000-crore expressway opened to traffic if a critical drainage system had not been commissioned? And why

When the New Doesn't Stay New for Very Long

The list below is telling, particularly because it not an exhaustive one, only indicative of recent failures.

|                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <br><b>1</b><br>The Rs 12,000-crore-plus corridor was inaugurated on April 14. A pothole was reported within days. In July, a section of the road surface caved in after heavy rain. | <br><b>2</b><br>The Rs 4,200-crore, 63-km expressway was opened in July. Surface damage and slippage were reported within weeks, prompting repairs and suspension of toll collection. | <br><b>3</b><br>A section of the 4.7-km bridge over the Mahisagar collapsed in May, and there have been reports of multiple internal warnings for 20 months prior to the failure. | <br><b>4</b><br>Portion of the 43-year-old bridge over the Mahisagar collapsed in July 2025, killing many as vehicles plunged into the river. The bridge had undergone repairs in 2024. | <br><b>5</b><br>Built in 1917, the bridge was declared unsafe and faced demolition, highlighting the gap that can exist between the intended life of public infrastructure and its actual serviceability. |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

should the motorist who pays toll have to discover the fallout, play guinea pig behind the wheel? **Thirteen Days**

The Delhi-Dehradun episode is not alone. The Rs 4,200-crore Lucknow-Kanpur Expressway suffered surface slippage just 13 days after its inauguration. NHAI has pointed out that this was a 'slippage' of the upper wearing over a 40-metre stretch, not a structural cave-in. But the distinction, important as it is technically, does not answer the larger question: Why was a Rs 4,200-crore expressway requiring repairs less than two weeks after being opened in the first place? (Toll collection was suspended while repairs were undertaken).

Think about this. An expressway is inaugurated with pomp and show. Toll collection begins. The road begins developing defects. Toll is suspended. Repairs begin. Is this what infrastructure delivery is supposed to look like? If the answer is that the defects are covered by a defect-liability period, another question follows: Why are taxpayers and motorists being asked to rely on a warranty, rather than quality in the first place? **The Human Cost**

This isn't a claim that every crack means corruption. It does not. Not every pothole means inferior material. It doesn't. Rain can damage roads. Soil can behave unpredictably. Drainage can fail. Construction defects can occur. But when

incidents involving new infrastructure keep appearing, the burden of proof cannot forever rest on the public accepting one explanation after another. At some point, the system must answer.

India recorded about 4.73 lakh road accidents and 1.70 lakh deaths in 2024, according to government data cited by a Parliamentary Committee. Over 52,600 of those deaths occurred on National Highways. The Ministry's 2023 data also recorded 311 deaths in pothole-related accidents in India's 10 lakh-plus cities. Not every one of those deaths can be blamed on bad roads. That would be dishonest. But neither can road quality be treated as a cosmetic issue. A pothole at highway speed can kill. A depression can throw a vehicle off line. A failed retaining wall can bury a road. A bridge failure can become a mass-casualty event.

And bridges have been giving us their own warnings. In May, the 4.7-km Vikramshila bridge over the Ganga in Bihar partially collapsed. According to some media reports, there were reportedly several warnings issued between August 2024 and April 2026, raising concerns about the bridge's condition. That is the part that should really worry us.

A structure does not suddenly become unsafe merely because someone discovers it one morning. There are inspections, engineers, reports, maintenance contracts, consultants, officials and agencies responsible for monitoring.

When warnings are raised and something still fails, the obvious question is not simply why did the bridge collapse? It is: Who knew? Who acted? Who didn't? And who will be held responsible? **The Accountability Gap**

This is where the infrastructure story begins to sport a credibility gap. Because officialese speaks of modern construction techniques, sophisticated monitoring, satellite imagery, geospatial technology and world-class engineering. NHAI has been using satellite, geospatial and UAV technologies for highway planning and monitoring for years. Its annual report says defect-liability periods have been extended to five or 10 years, while equipment-based monitoring has been introduced to improve pavement quality and riding life.

That's excellent. But it doesn't explain why then are we still fixing new roads? Why are taxpayers becoming beta testers for expressways costing thousands of crores? Why is the public discovering defects before the agencies entrusted with preventing them? And perhaps the most relevant question: When a project fails prematurely, where does accountability stop? With the contractor? Engineer? Consultant? The supervising authority? Or does it disappear somewhere between the tender document and the repair crew?

There is a deeply-ingrained habit of celebrating the comple-

tion of a project, choosing to treat its real-world performance as an afterthought. Get it built. Get it inaugurated. Put up the photographs. Move on. If something cracks, patch it. If it sinks, fill it. If a bridge develops problems, inspect it. If it falls, investigate it. And meanwhile, keep starting other new projects, sometimes even with those who are being investigated.

That is not infrastructure policy. It is infrastructure roulette. Yes, India absolutely needs more highways. It needs faster roads, better connectivity and world-class infrastructure. The scale of the nation's ambition is impressive and should be acknowledged. But ambition cannot be the excuse for shoddy execution. Nor can speed become a substitute for durability.

NHAI already has defect-liability provisions. It has engineers, consultants, monitoring systems and contractual safeguards. The country has the technology and engineering talent.

No Mystery Left

Things are going wrong. And somewhere, people are responsible for them going wrong. The answer cannot always be another patch of asphalt. It has to be accountability. Contractors responsible for proven failures must face consequences. Engineers and consultants who certify defective work cannot simply move on to the next project. Independent quality audits must be genuinely independent. Defect-liability clauses must be enforced. No project should be considered a success merely because a dignitary has inaugurated it.

A road is not an engineering achievement because it survives the inauguration ceremony. It is one if it survives the monsoon, the traffic, the years and, eventually, the people who built it. If India is building for 2047, it should stop measuring infrastructure in kilometres constructed and crores spent. It should measure it in years of safe service delivered. Because a road that lasts a generation is infrastructure.

A road that begins disappearing after its inauguration is something else. Road today, gone tomorrow.

Views expressed are personal

New Momentum Down Under

From uranium supplies to maritime security, India and Australia are expanding cooperation to address emerging economic and Indo-Pacific strategic challenges

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Australia visit (July 8-10), soon after a visit to Indonesia, proved an all-round success in terms of several deals in different areas, bringing both countries strategically closer.

Here, it may be recalled that India is Australia's fifth-largest trading partner after China, Japan, the U.S. and South Korea, while around 1 million people in Australia claim Indian ancestry, out of a population of 28 million, as evident from the available figures furnished by the Australian government. Two-way trade in goods and services was valued at \$4.4 billion Australian dollars (US\$37.7 billion) during the 2024-2025 financial year, according to Australian government figures. Among the multiple deals India and Australia signed during Prime Minister Modi's recent visit, perhaps the most important is the agreement between Australia and India to export Australian uranium to India for use in nuclear energy.

According to news portal Al Jazeera, Prime Minister Modi signed an important agreement on nuclear energy with Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese in Melbourne on July 9. This, as per Al Jazeera, will pave the way for uranium supplies from Australia to India and give clean energy objectives fresh momentum. It is believed in knowledgeable quarters that India has long eyed Australia's uranium reserves, which make up around 28 per cent of the world's supply, to help meet a target of 100 gigawatts of nuclear energy capacity by 2047, while Australia is looking to diversify trade beyond its reliance on China, its top affiliate. The exports would fall under safeguards established by the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). The arrangement facilitates Australian uranium exports to India to help increase the share of non-fossil-fuel power capacity. It is also relevant to mention that India and Australia had entered into a nuclear cooperation agreement in 2014. However, Australia exported only limited supplies of uranium to India, apprehending that the material could be used for making weapons.

Meanwhile, according to Jacob Shetye-man of the *Canberra Times*, the agreement signed will allow Australian companies to sell uranium ore to the rapidly expanding Indian market. As India tries to decarbonise and massively increase its power supply to fuel its bid to become an artificial intelligence powerhouse, Australian miners are anticipating soaring uranium demand and prices. But notwithstanding the world's largest uranium reserves, Australia is only the



The Modi-Albanese engagement marks a new chapter in India-Australia relations, driven by strategic trust and shared Indo-Pacific priorities

fourth-largest producer of the radioactive ore. That is because uranium mines currently operate only in South Australia and the Northern Territory. In every other state, new uranium mines are banned.

Interestingly, Australian Minerals Council Chief Executive Tania Constable says the opportunity to supply a potentially immense Indian nuclear generation programme adds further impetus to overturn outdated and ideologically driven bans on uranium mining. This includes state mining bans in New South Wales (NSW), Queensland and Western Australia (WA), as well as archaic federal laws.

Both Prime Ministers also agreed to strengthen defence cooperation and bolster supply chains for critical minerals. The two nations also plan to build a "temporary space tracking terminal" on Australia's Cocos Keeling Islands in the Indian Ocean, which will support Indian spaceflight projects. After meeting Modi at the business event, Albanese called the Indian leader a "living bridge" between Australia and India, saying Modi's vision had helped reshape the roadmap for Australia's economic engagement with India.

In the meantime, reacting to the agreements and developing strategic cooperation in the aftermath of Prime Minister Modi's visit and the different pacts signed, Chandrajit Banerjee, Director General, Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), opines that Australia has emerged as one of India's most consequential strategic partners in the Indo-Pacific. As a Quad member, a trusted supplier of critical minerals, a reliable energy partner and a champion of a rules-based maritime order, Australia has a crucial place in India's regional structure. Similarly, India has also

become central to Australia's vision of diversifying economic partnerships, strengthening regional resilience and balancing strategic risks in the Indo-Pacific. The most significant outcome was the Joint Declaration on Defence and Security Cooperation, replacing the 2009 security declaration with a far more ambitious framework. Together with the new Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the Indian Coast Guard and Australia's Maritime Border Command, these initiatives strengthened the architecture for maritime domain awareness, humanitarian assistance, disaster relief and coordinated responses across the Indian Ocean.

Further, the agreement, according to CII, significantly broadens defence collaboration by focusing on military interoperability, maritime security, defence industrial cooperation, cybersecurity, counter-terrorism, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief, and cooperation through regional groupings, including the Quad, ASEAN, the Indian Ocean Rim Association (IORA) and the Pacific Islands Forum (PIF). Equally significant was the launch of the Australia-India Partnership on Cyber, Critical Technologies and Supply Chains. It takes cooperation beyond research collaboration to include resilient semiconductor supply chains, trusted digital infrastructure, artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, biotechnology and defence innovation. The framework also positions India and Australia as partners in shaping technology governance.

Economic security emerged as another pillar. India is already Australia's fifth-largest trading partner, with two-way trade in goods valued at over \$24 billion in 2025-26. At the summit, both leaders reaffirmed their com-

mitment to concluding a comprehensive economic cooperation agreement, building upon the gains of the economic cooperation and trade agreement. Greater emphasis was placed on reducing non-tariff barriers, encouraging greater investment flows and strengthening business-to-business engagement. Critical minerals cooperation deserves particular attention. Secure access to lithium, cobalt, nickel and rare earth elements has become a strategic necessity today. Australia's resource base complements India's expanding manufacturing ambitions. The summit's focus on long-term offtake arrangements, joint processing capabilities, geological collaboration and supply chain resilience lays the foundation for a partnership that extends well beyond commodity trade into value addition and advanced manufacturing. Energy cooperation has similarly secured strategic importance. Against the backdrop of continuing geopolitical instability and disruptions in global energy markets, the Joint Statement on Energy Security echoed a pragmatic approach that balances energy transition with energy security.

Finally, education, skills and innovation continue to support the social dimension of the bilateral relationship. The approval of Australian university campuses in India, the establishment of a National Centre of Mining Equipment, Technology and Services at the National Skill Training Institute, Bhubaneswar, expanded vocational partnerships and growing research collaborations illustrate how human capital cooperation is evolving alongside strategic convergence.

The India-Australia partnership represents shared democratic values and historical goodwill, further reinforced by converging interests, economic complementarities and common regional responsibilities. Through the outcomes of PM Modi's visit, both countries emphasised the Indo-Pacific's crucial geopolitical influence and reaffirmed the need for a trusted partnership to deliver resilient supply chains, secure technologies and long-term regional stability. If the momentum built in Melbourne leads to prompt execution, as PM Modi put it, "Agenda focused like a one-day match, decisions as fast as a T20 and our partnership as long-lasting and deep as a Test match," the partnership will be well positioned to become one of the Indo-Pacific's most impactful strategic partnerships over the next decade. These points have all been comprehensively articulated by Chandrajit Banerjee, Director General, CII, in a recently published opinion piece in an Indian daily.

Views expressed are personal



UAE SAYS A SHIP WAS TARGETED IN THE STRAIT

# Iran makes new demands around Strait of Hormuz

DUBAI: Iran issued dramatic new demands around the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, and the United Arab Emirates said one of its ships was targeted by an Iranian missile. Yemen's military attacked the country's Iranian-backed Houthi rebels. And Turkey's Kurdish peace bill won approval in parliament.

Iran's politburo-like body known as the Supreme National Security Council said the Strait of Hormuz will not open until the United States "corrects its behaviour," issuing new demands that could shake up talks on a deal to manage the waterway.

Iran's state broadcaster published the statement by the council's secretary, Mohammad Bagher Zolghadr, who is also a commander in the powerful Revolutionary Guard.

The United States must never threaten Iran again, the statement said, and must permanently end the war with Iran and its armed allies in the region.

The US must lift the naval blockade of Iranian ports and withdraw its military from the area. It must "completely compensate" Iran for war damage, lift sanctions and "unconditionally" release frozen assets.

The US, which has wanted an acceptable deal first on the



Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, (centre) being surrounded by security personnel

### Key Points

- » US must never threaten Iran again, Tehran says
- » The US must lift the naval blockade of Iranian ports and withdraw its military from the area

strait before ending the blockade, had no immediate comment. According to the interim

deal signed in June, a schedule to end sanctions and plan on compensation would be part of the final deal, and negotiations would address frozen assets.

Iran has said it was close to reaching a separate deal with Oman to manage the strait, which runs between the two countries.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi earlier Saturday said they were close to reaching an agreement on navigation.

But the waterway's reopening is contingent on other conditions, he said in remarks shared on social media, and blamed the situation on what he called the US violation of the interim deal.

Oman, a mediator Gulf Arab country which has said relatively little on the talks, said in a statement discussions were ongoing "in a positive and constructive atmosphere," and condemned attacks on ships on the strait.

AGENCIES

## Houthi claim attack on Aramco oil facility in Saudi Arabia

SANAA: Yemen's Houthis attacked a crucial port on the Red Sea, killing people and further escalating the conflict over strategic waterways in the Middle East. They also said they attacked an oil facility on Sunday in southwestern Saudi Arabia, the latest attack by the Iranian-backed rebels on the kingdom.

Meanwhile, Iran has made new demands about the restart of negotiations and the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, the Pentagon is pressing the US defence industry to accelerate production of weapons, and Israel is insisting it won't withdraw from Gaza until Hamas disarms.

Here's a look at developments across the Middle East on Sunday. Full coverage can be found here.

The National Resistance Forces, a Yemeni government-allied force, said at least seven people — four troops and three civilians — were killed, and 15 civilians were injured in the Houthis' attacks Sunday on Mokha, a crucial port on the Red Sea.

Fayed al-Noman, assistant undersecretary of the information ministry, said the Houthis fired missiles and drones on the port, severely damaging its buildings and pier as well as commercial goods and food supplies at the facility.

AGENCIES

## Russia and Ukraine exchange overnight strikes that leave 7 dead

KYIV: Russia and Ukraine exchanged strikes overnight that killed civilians and injured many others on both sides, local authorities reported.

In Russia's border region of Belgorod, Ukrainian drones killed five people and injured two dozen others including a 4-year-old boy, according to the regional administration.

Russian missiles struck a high-rise apartment block in Kharkiv's Saltivskiy district, killing two people and injuring 13, according to regional head Oleh Syniehubov. Eight more people were injured in Ukraine's Black Sea port of Odesa after "dozens of missiles and drones" struck the city and surrounding region, according to local administration head Oleh Kiper.

Large-scale Russian missile strikes on Ukrainian cities have become almost routine in recent weeks, with Moscow exploiting Ukraine's critical shortage of interceptors for the US-made Patriot systems — the sole air defence weapon in its arsenal able to shoot down ballistic missiles.

Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has for months lobbied other countries, especially the US, to send Ukraine more Patriot systems made scarcer by the Iran war, arguing they are crucial for defending civilians.

Failing that, Zelenskyy wants to make Patriot ammunition in Ukraine or get approval from Elon Musk to use his Starlink satellite communications



Firefighters put out a fire after a residential building was hit following Russia's drone attack in Kharkiv on Sunday

AP/PTI

### Highlights

- » Ukrainian drones killed five people in border region of Belgorod
- » Large-scale Russian missile strikes on Ukrainian cities have become almost routine in recent weeks
- » Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has for months lobbied other countries
- » Russia's defence ministry on Sunday claimed its overnight strikes hit drone warehouses in the Kharkiv region

up long-range drone strikes against Russian energy infrastructure, as well as the country's largest online retailer, Wildberries, and other targets deep inside Russia, sparking a fuel crisis.

Russia's defence ministry on Sunday claimed its overnight strikes hit drone warehouses in the Kharkiv region, as well as fuel depots and stores of other materiel belonging to Ukraine's armed forces at the port of Odesa.

It said its forces had shot down 153 Ukrainian drones during the night, including over Russian-occupied Crimea and the Black and Azov seas.

In Russia's Belgorod region, the authorities said Ukrainian drone strikes damaged 29 apartment blocks and five private houses, as well as administrative buildings and unspecified "commercial facilities."

AGENCIES

## No Ebola cases found on quarantined river boat in Congo, say authorities

KINSHASA: No cases of Ebola have been detected among passengers on a river boat that was placed in quarantine near Kinshasa, health authorities have said.

The confirmation announced on Saturday eased concerns that the rare Bundibugyo virus might spread to the Congolese capital.

More than 200 boat passengers were placed in quarantine on Thursday in the port of Maluku, 65 kilometres (40 miles) from Kinshasa, after one traveller who was previously aboard the boat died with symptoms matching the Ebola virus.

Specialist teams from the Ministry of Health were deployed to Maluku to examine all of those on board. Those exhibiting suspicious symptoms had samples taken and sent to a laboratory for analysis, the ministry said on Saturday, adding that the vessel was also decontaminated.

The National Institute of Biomedical Research, which is responsible for testing, said that all suspected cases tested negative for Bundibugyo. It urged the population of Kinshasa to remain

calm. Congo has been battling an Ebola outbreak that has been deemed the fastest in history in terms of transmission, with confirmed cases since it started in May reaching 4,200, including over 1,900 deaths.

The river boat passenger had become sick and disembarked nearly three weeks ago in Pimu, in the province of Mongala, more than 1,000 kilometers from Kinshasa along the Congo River, Africa CDC Director-General Jean Kaseya said on Thursday. The capital has no confirmed Ebola case, he added.

News of the passenger's death caused panic in Kinshasa, which is far from the eastern region hit by the outbreak, the second-largest outbreak on record, behind the 2014-2016 West Africa outbreak that recorded more than 28,000 cases, including over 11,000 deaths.

Ebola is highly contagious and spreads through contact with bodily fluids such as vomit, blood or semen, and with contaminated surfaces and materials such as bedding and clothing.

AGENCIES

## Sharif's PML(N) on back foot on PoK protesters; calls them 'patriots'

ISLAMABAD: Set to take charge of the so-called government in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir, the PML(N), headed by Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and his brother Nawaz, seems to be on the back foot in dealing with protesters in the region, following months of violence. Prime Minister's adviser Rana Sanaullah on Saturday said 99 per cent of the protesters in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) are "patriotic" people.

He further said the political party's representatives would soon meet members of the banned Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC) - a collective of activists that have been spearheading protests in the region. Till a few days ago, the political party maintained that members of the banned terrorist group Tehrik-e Taliban were present among the protesters, to justify the government's crackdown on them.

Addressing a rally on Saturday, ahead of the third phase of "elections" in PoK, Sanaullah said: "Ninety-nine per cent of those associated with the Joint Awami Action Committee are

## In the two phases of the polls held so far, the establishment-backed PML(N) has won 25 seats

our patriotic brothers."

India maintains that the entire Union Territories of Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh are integral and inalienable parts of it. New Delhi also asserts that Pakistan has been in "illegal and forcible occupation" of parts of these Union Territories. Sanaullah further said on Saturday, "When the PML(N) government will be formed with two-third majority, it will sit with [Joint Awami] Action Committee representatives. Their first task will be to resolve this issue."

In the two phases of the polls held so far, the establishment-backed PML(N) has won 25 seats - crossing the majority mark in the so-called assembly in PoK, which has 45 elected seats, amid widespread violence and allegations of massive rigging.

AGENCIES

## Wildfire in Indonesian national park grows

JAKARTA: Indonesia sent air-planes and hundreds of firefighters on Sunday to fight a blaze in a popular national park, one of a growing number of wildfires the country is battling during an unusually dry season.

The largest fire reported this week has burned about 176 hectares (435 acres) of Mount Bromo, located within the Bromo Tengger Semeru National Park in East Java province, one of Indonesia's best-known tourist destinations.

Authorities closed the park to visitors Saturday and Rudijanta Tjahja Nugraha, the park chief, said the shutdown would remain in effect until further notice.

Hundreds of firefighters, disaster management personnel, police, soldiers, park rangers and volunteers have been mobilized to contain the blaze. Helicopters and drones have also been deployed to help battle the fire, while crews have built firebreaks to try to prevent further spread.

AGENCIES

## China issues red alert as Typhoon Dolphin hits its eastern coast



A man fights to hold onto his umbrella in strong wind and rain ahead of Typhoon Dolphin at Huangpu district of Shanghai on Sunday

AP/PTI

BEIJING: China's national observatory issued a red alert -- the highest level in the country's typhoon warning system -- as Typhoon Dolphin hit Zhejiang province on the eastern coast on Sunday afternoon.

Typhoon Dolphin, the 13th typhoon of the year in China, made landfall with a maximum sustained wind of 42 metres

per second, making it a severe typhoon upon landfall.

The red alert was required due to the typhoon's heavy rainfall intensity, extensive impact range and prolonged duration, said Wang Haiping, National Meteorological Centre (NMC) chief forecaster.

From Sunday to Wednesday,

regions including northern Fujian, Zhejiang, Shanghai, northern Jiangxi, Jiangsu, Anhui, eastern Hubei, central and eastern Henan, and southern Shandong will be hit by heavy downpours, with some areas in central-eastern Zhejiang and southern Anhui facing severe torrential rain.

AGENCIES

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AGENCIES

## Women's public role shrinks in China as official rhetoric shifts towards family, children: Study

From 2020 onwards, a modest rebound in references linking women to public roles was observed

BEIJING: The Chinese Communist Party (CPC) has long portrayed the protection of women's rights as one of its achievements but studies have found that their role in public life has diminished in recent years, particularly at the highest levels of political and policy leadership.

For decades, the Party promoted Mao Zedong's famous slogan that "women hold up half the sky" as a guiding principle for gender equality. But the narrative in China's official media has shifted in recent years, increasingly emphasising women's domestic and familial roles, according to a recent study that analysed articles in the People's Daily, the CPC's official mouthpiece.

The ruling CPC, which exercises tight political control over the country, has for decades claimed that women have played an active role in "socialist modernisation and reform and opening up".

However, a widening gap in the portrayal of women began to emerge in the late 1990s, according to the study by two



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

Hong Kong-based researchers. Published in the journal Frontiers in Sociology in May, the study found that the People's Daily had increasingly associated women with domestic and family roles while giving less prominence to their roles in the public sphere.

The researchers, Jia Wang of Hong Kong Polytechnic University and Ruiyu Zhang of the University of Hong Kong, analysed more than 125,000 articles published in the People's Daily between 1990 and 2023.

They identified vocabulary associated with the public sphere, including terms such as "leading woman", "fighter", "career" and "entrepreneurship", and words associated with the private sphere, such as "family", "childbearing", "housework" and "loving mother".

The researchers then examined how frequently neutral terms such as "female" and "woman" appeared near words from the two groups over the years.

The study found that the association between women and the private sphere remained strong throughout published an article covering parts of the study on Sunday. In the early 1990s, refer-

### Takeaways

- » For decades, the Party promoted Mao Zedong's famous slogan that "women hold up half the sky" as a guiding principle for gender equality
- » The researchers then examined how frequently neutral terms such as 'female' and 'woman' appeared near words from the two groups over the years

ences linking women to public roles were also relatively strong, nearly matching those associated with the private sphere.

One example was a 1992 People's Daily article titled "In the past, women were said to be inferior to men; today, they hold up half the sky", which described a labour competition and said women played an active role in "socialist modernisation and reform and opening up".

AGENCIES

## World Briefs

### SYRIA AGREES DEAL WITH RUSSIA OVER FUTURE USE OF MEDITERRANEAN BASES

DAMASCUS: Syria and Russia have reached an agreement over the future of two strategic Mediterranean coastal bases that ultimately ends their use as military outposts for Moscow, Syria's Foreign Ministry said Sunday. Russia was the top political and military ally of ousted President Bashar Assad between 2011 and 2024 when Syria fought against an Islamist-led armed opposition of which current interim President Ahmad al-Sharaa was a prominent militant leader. Throughout the conflict, the Hmeimeim air base near Latakia and the Tartus naval base were key Russian outposts in the eastern Mediterranean.

### BOAT CAPSIZES IN NEW YORK HARBOUR, WOMAN AND 5-MONTH-OLD BABY DIE

NEW YORK: The operator of a boat that capsized in New York Harbour, killing a mother and her infant daughter, is facing criminal charges, and authorities are investigating whether the vessel was an illegal charter, the US Coast Guard said Sunday. The 22-foot Bayliner speedboat overturned around 10:25 pm Saturday near Liberty Island, home to the Statue of Liberty, the US Coast Guard said. Twelve people were rescued from the water before police arrived, and police divers later located the 27-year-old woman and the 5-month-old girl in the water. Both were taken to a hospital where they were pronounced dead. According to the Coast Guard, the others were in stable condition.



# Govt may hike threshold for CCEA FDI approval to ₹15K cr

## The present threshold for foreign direct investment proposals requiring approval from CCEA is Rs 5,000 cr

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** The government is considering a proposal to raise the threshold for foreign direct investment proposals requiring approval from the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs to Rs 15,000 crore from Rs 5,000 crore at present to further improve the country's investment climate, according to sources.

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) is a high-level committee headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Its members include key Union Cabinet ministers such as the Home Minister and Finance Minister.

As per the existing foreign direct investment (FDI) policy, in case of proposals involving total foreign equity inflow of more than Rs 5,000 crore, the competent authority places the application for consideration of the CCEA. Below this limit, respective line ministries take a decision.

The existing limit has remained unchanged since November 2015.

Sources said that prevailing economic conditions, inflation, the growing scale of investments over the years, and the objective of promoting



**Prevailing economic conditions, inflation, growing scale of investments over the years & objective of promoting ease of doing business necessitate a review of the existing threshold, sources said**

ease of doing business necessitate a review of the existing threshold.

Earlier, a committee of secretaries, in its meeting, also suggested upward revision of the CCEA approval limit for FDI proposals requiring the government approval route.

The proposal is at a discussion stage, they said.

The government is also considering a proposal to ease FDI norms for downstream

investments to boost overseas fund inflows and create jobs.

As per the proposal, the government is considering exempting indirect foreign investment in Indian companies from obtaining its fresh nod where the upstream domestic firm has already received such approval.

At present, prior government approval is required for downstream or indirect foreign investment in two cases

### HIGHLIGHTS

- » Earlier, a committee of secretaries, in its meeting, also suggested upward revision of the CCEA approval limit for FDI proposals requiring the govt approval route
- » Govt is also considering a proposal to ease FDI norms for downstream investments to boost overseas fund inflows
- » Govt has taken a series of steps to attract overseas investments. The inflows have crossed \$1.16 trillion during April 2000-March 2026

— sectors under the government approval route for FDI and investments from countries sharing a land border with India.

The government has taken a series of steps to attract overseas inflows. The investments have crossed \$1.16 trillion during April 2000 and March 2026.

The top ten investors include Mauritius, Singapore, the US, the Netherlands, Japan, the UK and the UAE.

# GOBARdhan Scheme can help reduce gas import bill by \$5 billion, says IBA

*India imports around 50 per cent of its natural gas requirements, which exposes the Indian economy to volatile international prices & geopolitical risks*

### OUR CORRESPONDENT

**NEW DELHI:** Indian Biogas Association (IBA) on Sunday said it expects a \$5 billion reduction in the gas import bill due to the government's Rs 23,731-crore GOBARdhan Scheme, a circular bioenergy initiative to convert organic waste like agricultural and cow dung into clean energy.

According to an IBA statement, the recently approved GOBARdhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) with a financial outlay of Rs 23,731 crore, should be viewed as a strategic national investment rather than a public expenditure.

Its returns extend well beyond the bioenergy sector, generating measurable economic, environmental and social dividends through import substitution, rural development and improved agricultural productivity, it stated.

The largest economic payback will arise from reduced natural gas imports. India imports a significant amount (50 per cent) of its natural gas requirements, which exposes the Indian economy to volatile international prices and geopolitical risks.

In FY 2024 -25, the LNG import bill accounted for \$15.2 billion (approximately Rs 1.28 lakh crore, assuming an average



**In FY2024-25, LNG import bill accounted for \$15.2 billion (approximately Rs 1.28 lakh crore, assuming an average exchange rate of Rs 84/USD) and though FY26 data is not yet published, it is surely a sharp jump over the previous year**

exchange rate of Rs 84/USD), and though the FY25 -26 data is not yet published, it is surely a sharp jump over the previous year, owing to the prolonged West Asia crisis and plummeting INR against USD, according to the association.

Even with a conservative estimate of 1500 fully functional CBG plants in the forthcoming years, the trade deficit on account of natural gas import shall be at least diminished by one-third of its current level, i.e. \$5 billion (approximately Rs 40 lakh crore).

Another significant source of payback is the reduction in fertiliser imports and subsidy burden. CBG facilities produce Fermented Organic Manure (FOM) and liquid bio-slurry rich in essential plant nutrients. Their use supplements chemical fertilizers, particularly imported phosphatic and potassic fertilizers, while reducing dependence on subsidised urea. It stated that lower fertiliser imports and subsidy requirements translate into significant fiscal savings, making the scheme economically self-reinforcing.

In FY25, fertiliser import bill accounted for \$18 billion (approximately Rs 1.5 lakh crore). With the estimated 1500 functional CBG plants and adoption of Good Agricultural Practices (optimal blend of synthetic and organic manure), at least 5 per cent of the imports can be reduced, translating into a contribution to the reduction in the Current Account deficit by \$1 billion.

The scheme also delivers significant employment generation opportunities, more particularly in the rural areas, thus stimulating local economies and creating skilled as well as semi-skilled livelihoods.

GOBARdhan can transform agricultural residues into income-generating assets for farmers. Healthier soils require lower chemical inputs and ensure a sustainable increase in crop quality. The environmental payback is equally substantial as setting up CBG plants discourages open burning of biomass, a major contributor to air pollution, more apparent and revealing in the NCR region.

IBA is the first & largest nationwide professional biogas association for stakeholders of the biogas industry, including technology providers, project developers, plant operators & planners of biogas plants, and representatives from public policy, science & research in India.

## FPIs infuse ₹12,921 crore in first week of August



**NEW DELHI:** Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) maintained their buying spree in Indian equities, investing Rs 12,921 crore in the first week of August, driven by improving macroeconomic conditions, expectations of US rate cuts, lower crude oil prices and a stable rupee.

The inflow follows a Rs 20,200-crore investment in July, marking a sharp turnaround after four consecutive months of heavy selling.

FPIs had withdrawn Rs 49,340 crore in June, Rs 32,963 crore in May, Rs 60,847 crore in April and a massive Rs 1.17 lakh crore in March. Prior to this selling streak, they had invested Rs 22,615 crore in February, according to CDSL data.

Despite the recent buying, foreign investors have remained net sellers in Indian equities in 2026, withdrawing Rs 2.41 lakh crore so far, already exceeding the Rs 1.66 lakh crore outflow recorded during the entire 2025.

Market experts said the recent inflows reflect improving investor sentiment, supported by expectations of US rate cuts, softer crude prices and a stable rupee.

## ‘Retail participation in financial markets to deepen as savings shift to market-linked assets’

**NEW DELHI:** Retail participation in India's financial markets is likely to deepen further as rising financial literacy, digital access and regulatory reforms continue to shift household savings towards market-linked instruments, according to the SEBI's Annual Report 2025-26.

The regulator's latest data points to continued expansion in mutual funds, SIPs and other professionally managed investment products, while stronger investor-protection measures are expected to support broader participation.

India's financial landscape is undergoing a structural transformation, with investors increasingly favouring financial assets over traditional instruments, the report said.

Mutual funds remain central to this transition, supported by digital onboarding and grow-



ing accessibility of systematic investment plans (SIPs).

SEBI said the mutual fund industry's total assets under management more than doubled over the past five years, rising from Rs 31.43 lakh crore in March 2021 to Rs 73.7 lakh crore by March 2026.

The number of unique mutual fund investors rose 13.2 per cent year-on-year to 6.1 crore in 2025-26. Importantly, the expansion is increasingly broad-based, with Tier III cities accounting for 55

per cent of the investor base, indicating deeper penetration beyond major urban centres. SIPs also strengthened their role as a vehicle for disciplined, long-term investing, with gross inflows rising 20.8 per cent during the year.

SIP accounts increased to 1,045 lakh in 2025-26 from 1,005 lakh a year earlier, while assets accumulated through SIPs rose to Rs 15.1 lakh crore from Rs 13.35 lakh crore.

Gross SIP inflows climbed to Rs 3.5 lakh crore, while net inflows increased to Rs 1.97 lakh crore.

The broader mutual fund industry also recorded strong growth, with AUM rising 12.2 per cent to Rs 73.7 lakh crore.

Equity-oriented schemes attracted net inflows of Rs 3.5 lakh crore, while passive investment continued to gain traction.

Net inflows into passive schemes rose to Rs 2.1 lakh crore from Rs 1.4 lakh crore in 2024-25.

At the same time, SEBI is tightening safeguards as participation expands. Stress tests showed that large small-cap schemes could require substantially longer periods to liquidate portfolios under high redemption pressure, highlighting liquidity and concentration risks.

Going ahead, the combination of digital access, rising investor awareness and regulatory simplification could support sustained growth in financial-market participation. SEBI's revised mutual fund regulations are aimed at improving clarity while retaining and strengthening investor-protection, transparency and governance standards.

## ‘Domestic investors’ share in Indian equities rises to all-time high of 17%

**NEW DELHI:** Domestic institutional investors increased their share in Indian equities to record high of 17 per cent by the end of March 2026, while the share of foreign portfolio investors fell to a 15-year low of 15.8 per cent, according to the SEBI's Annual Report 2025-26.

The shift came during a year when FPOs pulled money out of the Indian market amid heightened global uncertainty, while domestic institutional investors (DIIs) continued to invest.

SEBI said DIIs, including banks, development financial institutions, insurance companies, mutual funds and the National Pension System, recorded a cumulative net investment of Rs 8.5 lakh crore during 2025-26.

"Despite this volatility, DIIs, comprising Banks, DFIs,

insurance, mutual funds and NPS, acted as a critical countervailing force, absorbing foreign divestments with a record cumulative net inflow of Rs 8.5 lakh crore, heavily supported by consistent mutual fund SIPs," SEBI said in the report.

This pushed the share of domestic institutional investors in Indian equities to a record level even as foreign investor ownership declined.

The shift also reflects the growing role of domestic savings in India's capital markets. Mutual fund investments through SIPs remained a major source of domestic money during the year.

According to the report, the number of SIP accounts increased 3.9 per cent to 10.45 crore in FY26 from 10.05 crore in the previous financial year. Average net monthly SIP

investments increased 25.8 per cent to Rs 16,413 crore from Rs 13,052 crore. The domestic buying helped cushion Indian markets during a volatile year. The Nifty 50 touched a record high of 26,328.6 in early January 2026 before geopolitical tensions in the Middle East led to a correction. The index ended the fiscal with a decline of 5.1 per cent.

Foreign investment was affected by global factors, including geopolitical tensions in West Asia, elevated crude oil prices and rising US bond yields, which led investors to move money across global markets during the year. Despite volatility, India remained the world's 5th-largest stock market, with total market capitalisation at Rs 41.16 lakh crore at FY26 end, according to the SEBI report.

### CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



**In a landmark development aimed at strengthening the Ladakh Pashmina sector and empowering the nomadic Pashmina herders, Lt. Governor, Vinai Kumar Saxena on Sunday disbursed Rs 1.10 crore to over 1200 Pashmina herders as part of the production-based incentive, announced in the first meeting of Ladakh Pashmina Development Board on 5 July 2026. Saxena, who was in Korkot to attend the Changthang Nomadic Festival 2026, on the banks of pristine Tso (Lake) Moriri, said the 25 per cent production-based incentive would enhance the income, profitability and sustainability of nomadic Pashmina growers.**

## Four of top-10 cos add ₹1.43 lakh cr in mcap

*From the top-10 pack, Reliance Industries, SBI, TCS & L&T were gainers*

**NEW DELHI:** The combined market valuation of four of the top-10 most valued firms jumped Rs 1.43 lakh crore last week, with State Bank of India emerging as the biggest gainer.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex climbed 404.53 points, or 0.51 per cent, and the NSE Nifty went up by 187.05 points, or 0.76 per cent.

"Markets ended the week with modest gains despite heightened volatility, as investors navigated the roll-out of the new Closing Auction Session (CAS) framework for F&O stocks, the Reserve Bank of India's monetary policy decision, and lingering geopolitical uncertainties," Ajit Mishra



– SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

From the top-10 pack, Reliance Industries, State Bank of India, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) and Larsen & Toubro were the gainers, while Bharti Airtel, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, Bajaj Finance, Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) and Hindustan Unilever

faced a combined erosion of Rs 1.23 lakh crore from their valuation.

State Bank of India added Rs 63,922.03 crore, taking its market valuation to Rs 10,11,721.84 crore.

The valuation of Reliance Industries jumped Rs 32,816.4 crore to Rs 18,01,925.19 crore, and that of TCS surged Rs 31,875.35 crore to Rs 8,87,770.13 crore.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of Larsen & Toubro climbed Rs 14,637.76 crore to Rs 5,56,482.45 crore.

However, the valuation of LIC tumbled Rs 40,543.23 crore to Rs 4,96,891.82 crore.

The mcap of Bajaj Finance

eroded by Rs 37,168.96 crore to Rs 6,73,648.55 crore, and that of HDFC Bank dropped Rs 24,183.16 crore to Rs 11,27,967.47 crore.

The valuation of ICICI Bank declined by Rs 9,507.67 crore to Rs 10,20,370.63 crore, and that of Bharti Airtel eroded by Rs 7,581.65 crore to Rs 12,22,423.98 crore.

The mcap of Hindustan Unilever dipped by Rs 4,793.16 crore to Rs 4,88,808.97 crore.

Reliance Industries remained the most valued firm, followed by Bharti Airtel, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, LIC and Hindustan Unilever.

## OIL CMD Ranjit Rath among applicants for ONGC top job

**NEW DELHI:** Oil India Ltd Chairman & MD (CMD) Ranjit Rath is among more than half a dozen candidates who have applied for the top post at state-run Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC), people familiar with the matter said.

Rath, 54, is seeking the position for the second consecutive year after the government relaxed the eligibility criteria, including the maximum entry age.

Other candidates include ONGC Videsh Ltd (OVL) MD Rajarshi Gupta, ONGC directors Vikram Saxena and Satyam Kumar, OVL Director Dulal Halder, MRPL Director (Finance) Devendra Kumar and Indian Oil Corporation Director (Marketing) S P Shrivastava.

The post will fall vacant on December 7 when incumbent Arun Kumar Singh completes his extended tenure. Applications closed on July 22.

The government has set the maximum entry age at 59 years and said the selected candidate will initially serve for three years, extendable by two years based on performance. The selection will be conducted by a search-cum-selection committee constituted by the oil ministry.

## US Senate Russia sanctions vote raises risk for Indian crude supplies: Kpler

*The measure still needs to clear US House of Representatives & faces further legislative, administrative steps before it could take effect*

**NEW DELHI:** A US Senate vote to advance tougher sanctions on Russia raises the risk of disruption to Russian crude supplies but is unlikely to immediately alter oil flows to India and China, according to Kpler analyst Sumit Ritolia.

The US Senate on Friday passed a bipartisan Russia sanctions bill that would give President Donald Trump authority to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on imports from countries that are among the world's largest buyers of Russian oil and gas. The Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia Act of 2026 targets the five biggest purchasers

of Russian energy and is aimed at cutting Moscow's revenues from oil and gas sales.

The measure still needs to clear the US House of Representatives and faces further legislative and administrative steps before it could take effect.

According to Ritolia, the measures still face further legislative and administrative hurdles, while their impact will depend largely on how aggressively the US administration implements them, including whether it grants exemptions or waivers. "Recent experience suggests that when physical supply security becomes a

### CLOSER LOOK

- » Impact will depend largely on how aggressively the US administration implements them, including any waivers
- » Kpler data show Indian refiners imported a record 2.8 million bpd of Russian crude in July 2026, accounting for 55.5% of total crude imports of just over 5 million bpd

concern, policymakers retain an incentive to avoid measures that could unnecessarily disrupt crude availability," he said.

The timing of any curbs is critical as global crude markets remain relatively tight and uncertainty over Middle Eastern supplies has increased

the importance of alternative sources, Ritolia said. A significant restriction on Russian oil could therefore tighten global balances rather than simply redirect existing trade flows.

India's dependence on Russian crude has surged since Russia's invasion of Ukraine

in February 2022, when Western sanctions and an exodus of European buyers left Moscow offering deep discounts to Asian refiners. Russia supplied less than 100,000 barrels per day to India in 2021, or about 2.5 per cent of its crude imports, according to the US Energy Information Administration. The volume rose to about 740,000 bpd in 2022 and nearly 1.8 million bpd in 2023, making Russia India's largest crude supplier with about 39 per cent of imports that year.

The dependence has since grown further. Kpler data show Indian refiners imported

a record 2.8 million bpd of Russian crude in July 2026, accounting for about 55.5 per cent of total crude imports of just over 5 million bpd. That compares with roughly 1.8 million bpd on average in 2024, according to Kpler-based data.

Ritolia said Russian crude has become an important supply hedge for Indian refiners, reducing their exposure to disruptions along traditional Middle Eastern supply routes.

This reliance became particularly evident during the recent period of heightened Middle East supply risks, when the US provided temporary sanctions

flexibility that allowed Russian barrels to continue flowing to India, he said. Replacing Russian crude at current volumes would be difficult, if not impossible, in short term, Ritolia said. A rapid curtailment of Russian supplies to India or other Asian buyers could therefore tighten global oil balances & put pressure on crude prices.

For India, the impact would extend beyond refinery procurement costs, potentially increasing the country's overall crude import bill, widening pressure on the current account and raising concerns over energy security.



DOMESTIC SUPPLY MEETS ABOUT 30%

# India’s nuclear power expansion may need 5,400 tonnes uranium annually

NEW DELHI: India’s planned expansion of nuclear power capacity could significantly increase its uranium requirement, with Pressurised Heavy Water Reactors (PHWRs) alone expected to need around 5,400 tonnes of uranium oxide annually, while domestic production currently meets about 30 per cent of this requirement, according to a Parliamentary Committee’s findings.

The Committee on Public Undertakings, in its report on action taken by the government on the performance of Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL), highlighted the country’s continued dependence on imported uranium and called for faster expansion of domestic production.

“Given that future PHWR expansions will require approximately 5,400 tonnes of U3O8 per annum, and domestic output currently satisfies about 30% of this baseline, accelerating domestic production remains an essential priority for comprehensive fuel assurance,” the Committee said.

The panel noted that the Nuclear Fuel Complex manufactures fuel assemblies for PHWRs in India using uranium concentrate supplied by Uranium Corporation of India Limited (UCIL) or through imports



The panel noted that the Nuclear Fuel Complex manufactures fuel assemblies for PHWRs in India using uranium concentrate supplied by Uranium Corporation of India Limited (UCIL) or through imports arranged under government oversight.

arranged under government oversight.

According to the report, uranium imports currently come from Kazakhstan, Russia, Uzbekistan and Canada, while a long-term supply contract with Uzbekistan is valid up to 2026.

The Committee also noted that a proposed joint venture between UCIL and NTPC to acquire stakes in overseas uranium assets could help secure supplies and reduce exposure

to fluctuations in the international market.

“The proposal for a joint venture between UCIL and NTPC to acquire stakes in overseas uranium assets is a constructive and encouraging step toward stabilizing long-term fuel costs and supporting the domestic nuclear fleet against market fluctuations and uncertainties,” it said.

However, the panel sought a more detailed plan and definite timelines from the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE).

## HIGHLIGHTS

- » ‘Uranium imports currently come from Kazakhstan, Russia, Uzbekistan & Canada. A long-term supply contract with Uzbekistan is valid up to 2026’
- » The panel also noted that a proposed UCIL-NTPC JV to acquire stakes in overseas uranium assets could help secure supplies
- » However, it sought a more detailed plan and definite timelines from the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE)

calibrated to refueling cycles and outage risks, is essential to sustaining reactor operations during supply disruptions,” the Committee said.

On domestic availability, the report noted that the Atomic Minerals Directorate for Exploration and Research has established around 4.31 lakh tonnes of uranium oxide resources in the country. Of around 80,423 tonnes transferred to UCIL, about 39.22 per cent has already been depleted. At current production rates, the remaining reserves could last around 40 years if no new reserves are added.

In its response to the Committee, DAE said UCIL plans to double uranium production by expanding existing mine capacity and setting up mining projects in Jharkhand, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh.

The uranium requirement assumes significance as India expands its nuclear power programme. NPCIL currently operates 25 reactors with an installed capacity of 8,780 MW, while another 17 reactors totaling 13,100 MW are under various stages of execution. The government has set a target of reaching 100 GW of nuclear power capacity by 2047, with NPCIL expected to contribute nearly half of it.

THE NUMBER STOOD AT 692 IN 2024

# ‘DGCA records 889 serious tech defects in flights last year’

The number of serious defects stood at 487 & 528 in 2023 and 2022, respectively. In 2021, the count was at 514

## OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Aviation watchdog DGCA recorded 889 serious technical defects in flights compared to 692 such faults in 2024, according to official data.

The number of serious defects recorded stood at 487 and 528 in 2023 and 2022, respectively. In 2021, the count was at 514.

These figures were shared by Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol in the Lok Sabha, as part of a written reply on August 6.

The minister was responding to queries by Congress member Shyamkumar Daulat Barve.

According to Mohol, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has laid down Civil Aviation Requirements (CARs), safety advisories, directives and other regulatory instructions to ensure safe aircraft operations.

“For monitoring compliance, DGCA has a systematic safety oversight mechanism encompassing all aircraft and airport operations.

“The safety oversight process includes regulatory audits,



## KEY POINTS

- » Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol said, DGCA has laid down Civil Aviation Requirements (CARs), safety advisories, directives and other regulatory instructions to ensure safe aircraft operations
- » DGCA took action for safety violations related to airlines & MRO in 42 cases last year, while the count was at 31 in 2024. In 2023, the number stood at 24, and 7 and 1 in 2022 and 2021, respectively, the data showed

night surveillance, ramp inspections, spot checks and special audits. DGCA publishes the Annual Surveillance Plan (ASP) on its website,” he said.

According to the data, DGCA took action for safety violations related to airlines

and MRO (Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul) in 42 cases last year, while the count was at 31 in 2024.

In 2023, the number stood at 24, and 7 and 1 in 2022 and 2021, respectively, the data showed.

## Gold, silver prices likely to extend rally next week

NEW DELHI: Gold and silver prices are expected to extend their gains next week, as inflation data from major economies and developments on efforts to end hostilities in West Asia are likely to set the tone for bullion, analysts said.

Investors will track inflation numbers from the US, Germany, Japan and India, while upcoming Chinese economic data will also be crucial for industrial metals, they added.

On the domestic front, gold futures for October delivery climbed Rs 8,444, or nearly 6 per cent, during the week to close at Rs 1.51 lakh per 10 grams.

Silver futures for the September contract surged Rs 14,268, or nearly 7 per cent, to settle at Rs 2.31 lakh per kilogram on the MCX.

“Gold witnessed a strong rally this week, gaining nearly 6 per cent, as weaker-than-expected US labour market data revived expectations of a more accommodative monetary policy from the Federal Reserve,” said Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst, Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities.

The weaker dollar also encouraged fresh buying in precious metals, allowing gold to post one of its strongest weekly gains in recent months, he added.

In the international markets, gold futures for the December delivery jumped \$292.7, or 7 per cent, to finish the week at \$4,399.7 per ounce, while silver for the September contract soared \$5.71, or nearly 10 per cent, to \$63.50 per ounce.

## India achieves 300 GW RE capacity, 60% of 500 GW target by 2030

NEW DELHI: India has achieved 300 GW, or 60 per cent of its non-fossil fuel power generation capacity target of 500 GW, the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy said on Sunday.

In a major milestone for the nation’s clean energy transition and climate action targets, India has crossed 300 GW of non-fossil fuel-based installed electricity generation capacity as on July 31, 2026; over 60 per cent of the 500 GW capacity targeted to be achieved by 2030, a ministry statement said.

The 300.50 GW non-fossil fuel capacity (as on July 31, 2026) includes solar power (164.59 GW), wind power (58.14 GW), hydro power (57.24 GW), bio-power (11.75 GW) and Nuclear Power (8.78 GW). The share of non-fossil fuel electricity capacity in the country’s total electricity generation capacity, which is around 552 GW at present, has reached



over 54 per cent.

Backed by the key policy enablers provided by the government for this transformation, this monumental achievement highlights India’s rapid progress towards building an Aatmanirbhar energy ecosystem and securing the target of 500 GW non-fossil capacity by 2030.

Solar energy remains the key growth engine, with around 165 GW at present, from just 2.8 GW in 2014. Concurrently, the wind energy sector has also seen strong momentum, reaching over 58 GW from 21 GW in 2014.

During 2025-26, a record

capacity of 55.29 GW of non-fossil fuel-based electricity capacity was installed in the country, with key contributions from 44.6 GW solar power and 6 GW wind power.

The rapid progress in renewable energy capacity is also reflected in renewable energy generation, which has increased from 190.96 billion units (BU) in 2014-15 to 477.79 BU in 2025-26.

To support this rapid expansion and ensure supply chain independence, India has transformed its domestic manufacturing capabilities. Driven by the PLI scheme focusing on the nation’s solar installations with high-efficiency, indigenously produced modules, the enlisted capacity under the Approved List of Models and Manufacturers (ALMM) for solar PV modules has crossed the historic 200 GW milestone, rising from just 2.3 GW in 2014, the statement said.

## Parliamentary panel flags gaps in BharatNet rollout, seeks state-wise performance audit

NEW DELHI: A Parliamentary panel has flagged gaps in the rollout of BharatNet, the government’s flagship rural broadband programme, and called for a comprehensive state-wise & implementation model-wise performance audit to identify bottlenecks & ensure connectivity across all Gram Panchayats.

The Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology, in its 32nd Report on Digital Bharat Nidhi, noted that while substantial infrastructure has been created under BharatNet, the number of operational Gram Panchayats remains below the programme’s envisaged universal coverage.

As of February 28, 2026, BharatNet Points of Presence (PoPs) were operational at 78,899 Gram Panchayats out of around 2.64 lakh across the country, according to information provided by the Department of Telecommunications to the Committee. A PoP is essentially a local network point from which broadband connectivity can be extended further to users.

“The Committee find that while substantial infrastructure has been created, the number of operational GPs has remained below the envisaged universal coverage and the pace of implementation is uneven across States and models. This indicates gaps in planning, coordination and execution,” the panel said.

It called upon the Department to undertake a “comprehensive, model-wise and State-wise performance audit” of BharatNet and identify and address bottlenecks in implementation. The Committee also sought a revised, time-bound roadmap with clear accountability for completing connectivity to all Gram Panchayats. The Department informed

the panel that 7.19 lakh kilometres of optical fibre cable had been laid under the programme as of February 28, 2026. Optical fibre cables form the backbone of the network and are used to transmit internet data over long distances.

It also said Rs 40,635 crore had been disbursed from Digital Bharat Nidhi for BharatNet Phase-I and Phase-II as of February 28. Digital Bharat Nidhi is a dedicated fund used to support expansion of telecom services, particularly in rural and underserved areas.

BharatNet was originally approved by the Union Cabinet as the National Optical Fibre Network in October 2011, with the aim of providing broadband connectivity to all Gram Panchayats. It was subsequently developed as BharatNet and became an important rural connectivity programme under the Digital India initiative. Phase-

I was completed in December 2017, while Phase-II was approved in July 2017.

The Committee also raised concerns over the utilisation of the infrastructure already created. The Department said there were 9,48,237 active Fibre-to-the-Home (FTTH) connections under BharatNet as of February 28, all of them in rural areas. FTTH means extending an optical fibre connection directly to homes or other users to provide broadband internet.

The panel said that despite extensive infrastructure and dedicated funding, utilisation remained “sub-optimal when compared to the scale and potential of the network”, adding that the benefits of digital connectivity had not fully reached rural and remote areas. It recommended greater focus on increasing FTTH connections and improving use of the existing network.

## ‘Strong credit growth and capital inflows likely to support Indian markets, rupee outlook improves’

NEW DELHI: India’s domestic growth momentum and improving capital flows could provide support to the Indian markets in the coming months, even as foreign investors’ overall equity exposure remains weak, according to a Jefferies research report.

Jefferies noted that India recorded net foreign buying of \$2.45 billion in equities in July, helped by an unwind of the memory trade. However, foreign investors remained net sellers of Indian equities to the tune of \$25.4 billion year-to-date, highlighting continued pressure from overseas flows.

The report said the more encouraging signal is coming from the domestic economy,

with bank credit growth accelerating to 17-18 per cent year-on-year, the highest level in more than a decade. Corporate lending has emerged as the strongest segment, growing at around 20 per cent, while loans to agriculture and retail expanded 17 per cent and 16 per cent, respectively.

Jefferies also pointed to healthy automobile and property demand, suggesting that domestic consumption and investment activity are providing an important counterbalance to volatile global capital flows.

The outlook for the rupee has also improved, supported by stronger foreign currency inflows. The Reserve Bank of

India’s scheme to attract foreign currency deposits from non-resident Indians has generated about \$41 billion of inflows so far. Jefferies expects the total to potentially rise to \$80-100 billion over the next two months before the scheme ends.

In addition, foreign investors have brought in \$8.7 billion into Indian government bonds since the beginning of June after interest income on such holdings was made tax-free. Jefferies said these developments increase the likelihood of rupee stabilisation. The currency, which had touched 96.96 per US dollar in May, was at 95.17 at the time of the report.

On monetary policy, the

report noted that the RBI kept its policy rate unchanged for the fourth consecutive meeting while retaining a neutral stance. Jefferies’ India strategist Mahesh Nandurkar expects only one 25-basis-point rate hike during the current tightening cycle.

Jefferies sees a more supportive domestic backdrop for India, driven by strong credit growth, resilient demand and improving foreign currency flows.

However, elevated cumulative foreign selling remains a key risk for the market, making the sustainability of domestic growth and further capital inflows important factors to watch ahead.

## ‘Crude prices, inflation data to drive markets this week’

NEW DELHI: Crude oil prices, tensions in West Asia, & upcoming inflation data will drive stock markets this week, according to analysts.

Moreover, developments surrounding the Strait of Hormuz, foreign investor trading activity, and domestic quarterly earnings will also remain key monitorables for the Indian stock market, experts added.

“Domestically, investors will closely monitor the July CPI inflation print, WPI inflation, and the latest foreign exchange reserves data for fresh insights into inflation trends and external sector stability. The Q1 FY27 earnings season will gather further momentum, with several companies, including HAL, Bharat Forge, Grasim Industries, and Tata Motors, scheduled to announce their quarterly results,” Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

Globally, market participants will continue to monitor developments surrounding the Strait of Hormuz, movements in crude oil prices, and broader geopolitical negotiations involving Iran, he added. “This week is likely to be shaped by two dominant themes: developments in the Middle East and the July US inflation report. Attention will remain firmly focused on the Middle East, where negotiations over the Strait of Hormuz remain fluid,” Ponmudi R, CEO – Enrich Money, an online trading & wealth tech firm, said. PTI

## BIS to scale up silver hallmarking amid gold buyers’ shift

Silver hallmarked has been voluntary since 2005 & from September 2025 onwards, hallmarked silver articles carry a Hallmark Unique Identification number, enabling buyers to verify purity

NEW DELHI: The Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) is preparing to significantly expand testing of silver jewellery as consumers increasingly shift from gold amid soaring prices, a senior official said.

BIS Deputy Director General (Laboratories) Nishat S Haque said the agency is equipped to handle rising demand for silver jewellery testing through its own laboratories for the next two years, while referral and assay laboratories will be expanded across the country during this period.

## CLOSER LOOK

- » The number of silver jewellery articles hallmarked rose to 5.9 million in FY26 from 3.2 million in FY25
- » BIS currently recognises around 230 Assaying and Hallmarking Centres for silver jewellery testing
- » ‘BIS conducts market surveillance testing of hallmarked gold jewellery through its own laboratories’

Silver hallmarked has been voluntary since 2005. Since September 2025, hallmarked silver articles have carried a Hallmark Unique Identification (HUID) number, allowing consumers to

verify purity.

The number of silver jewellery articles hallmarked rose to 5.9 million in FY26 from 3.2 million in FY25. BIS currently recognises around 230 Assaying

and Hallmarking Centres for silver jewellery testing. Haque said BIS conducts market surveillance testing of hallmarked gold jewellery through its own laboratories and does not outsource the activity.

BIS tested nearly 270,000 product samples in the past year. Its laboratory network has grown significantly, with 10 laboratories operated directly by the agency and 440 recognised laboratories, compared with 147 in 2014. The agency is also testing artificial intelligence, machine learning and robot-

ics to improve testing speed, transparency and accuracy. A pick-and-place robotic arm is being piloted for cement testing, while test equipment is being integrated with its Laboratory Information Management System (LIMS) to automate data capture and calculations.

BIS conducts surveillance of ISI-marked products, including helmets and appliances, through samples collected from physical and online markets. Consumers can lodge complaints about BIS-certified products through the BIS Care app.



THE SUMMIT CLASH LASTED 53 MINUTES

# Ashmita stuns Han to win maiden BWF Tour title at Korea Masters

ASAN: India's Ashmita Chaliha produced a gritty show to secure her maiden BWF World tour title with a fighting win over fourth seed Han Qian Xi of China in the women's singles final of the Korea Masters Super 300 badminton tournament here on Sunday.

The 26-year-old from Assam, who had suffered a career-threatening knee injury two years back in Korea, overcame a slow start and a testing decider to complete a memorable victory, recovering from the loss of the opening game to stun world No. 35 Han 14-21, 21-14, 21-14 in the summit clash that lasted 53 minutes.

"I feel really great and unbelievable. But then I am trying to digest it. Now, I am hungry for more," said Ashmita, who trains under Park Tae-Sang at the National Centre of Excellence in Guwahati.

"In the first game, it was a little bit tricky because of the drift conditions, so I was not able to manage it... But in the second, the other side was more comfortable and there was less drift, so I was able to control it. And in the third, after 11 points, I changed again, so I was on the good side. I'm glad that I could pull off."

Ashmita's win marks back-to-back BWF World Tour finals



Ashmita Chaliha

for Indians, with Tanvi Sharma having won the Taipei Open last Sunday.

Park, who has now seen two of his wards win Super 300 titles in successive weeks, believes Ashmita always had the tools to succeed but needed to become more consistent in her approach.

"Before the injury, Ashmita was already a good player and a very good talent. She has a

good smash and nice movement, but unfortunately, at the wrong time, she had to take a break because of the injury," the South Korean told PTI.

"When she joined me, I thought, 'Oh, she is a good player.' But tactically and strategically, and also a little bit mentally, she had some problems."

The world number 50 Ashmita had to undergo surgery and an extensive rehabilitation

In the final, Ashmita opened up a 3-0 start and had a 9-5 lead early on but Han made a stirring comeback as the two players were locked at 11-11

I FEEL REALLY GREAT AND UNBELIEVABLE. BUT THEN I AM TRYING TO DIGEST IT. NOW, I AM HUNGRY FOR MORE

period after suffering a medial meniscus tear in her right knee during the Korea Open in 2024. She returned in February next year and played 14 events.

This year she competed in a couple of events but then spent three months building strength to handle a full elite BWF calendar load.

She enjoyed a strong comeback on the BWF Tour with back-to-back quarterfinals at

China Masters and Malaysia Masters and then a semifinal appearance at the Macau Open.

Ahead of Sunday's final, Park and Ashmita analysed Han's game on video, with the coach identifying unforced errors as the biggest obstacle.

"Yesterday, we also did a video analysis of her Chinese opponent. I told Ashmita, 'Your biggest problem is your own mistakes. You are making simple mistakes. But if you can reduce those simple mistakes, 100 per cent, I promise you, you can win the title today,'" Park said.

In the final, Ashmita opened up a 3-0 start and had a 9-5 lead early on but Han made a stirring comeback as the two players were locked at 11-11.

The Chinese shuttler found another gear and a run of points helped her establish control as she closed out the game comfortably to earn the bragging rights.

Ashmita responded strongly in the second game. She attacked with greater authority, using her smashes to put Han under pressure while also producing some sharp defensive returns to break off after 6-6.

The Indian led 11-8 at the interval and continued to dictate the rallies thereafter. AGENCIES

# India beat Sri Lanka XI by six wickets in warm-up

India completed the target in 45 overs

COLOMBO: Yashasvi Jaiswal and Shubman Gill struck useful runs at the top of the order before Mohammed Siraj's late blitz helped India beat Sri Lanka Cricket XI by six wickets in their three-day warm-up game here on Sunday.

Chasing 207 for victory, India completed the target in 45 overs, finishing on 214 for four with Siraj smashing 32 off just 15 balls, including three successive sixes, to bring the game to an emphatic end.

Jaiswal, who had fallen for a duck in India's first innings, responded in style with a quickfire 61 off 46 balls. He and Gill put on exactly 105 for the opening wicket to give India a flying start to their chase.

Jaiswal retired after reaching his half-century to allow his teammates valuable time in the middle.

Gill, returning to action after missing the first two days of the fixture with a finger injury, made a useful 44 before being dismissed by spinner Keshara Nuwantha. His return to the middle was a significant positive for India ahead of the opening Test against Sri Lanka.

Dhruv Jurel chipped in with 17, while Rishabh Pant made a patient 28 before India were briefly reduced to 155 for three.

But the target was never in serious danger, with the lower order completing the chase



Jaiswal and Gill put on exactly 105 for the opening wicket

Earlier, Sri Lanka Cricket XI declared their second innings at 200 for six in 45 overs, leaving India a target of 207

In the final session, Siraj then provided the fireworks, hitting three consecutive sixes to finish the game in style. Earlier, Sri Lanka Cricket XI declared their second innings at 200 for six in 45 overs, leaving India a target of 207.

Opener Nishan Madushka, who had also scored a half-century in the first innings, top-scored with 63 off 73 balls, while Nipun Dhananjaya made

46 and Anjala Bandara contributed 35. Ravindra Jadeja and Gurnoor Brar claimed two wickets each for India, while Mohammed Siraj and Prasadh Krishna took one apiece.

India had earlier declared their first innings at 357 for six after Sri Lanka XI posted 363 for eight declared.

Devdutt Padikkal was the star of India's first-innings effort with an unbeaten 142, while Jadeja scored 63 and Manav Suthar contributed 41. Gurnoor Brar remained unbeaten on 36 as India finished just six runs behind the hosts. The warm-up game provided India with useful match practice ahead of the two-Test series against Sri Lanka, with the first match scheduled to begin in Galle on Aug 15. AGENCIES

# Sarfaraz Khan replaces injured Sai Sudharsan for Sri Lanka Tests

NEW DELHI: Mumbai batter Sarfaraz Khan on Sunday replaced injured Sai Sudharsan in the Indian squad for the Test series against Sri Lanka, starting August 15.

The left-handed Sudarshan had suffered a toe injury during the India A tour last month and is recovering at the BCCI Centre of Excellence (COE) in Bengaluru.

The BCCI said Sudarshan has made significant progress in his recovery and its medical team is closely monitoring his progress. "The men's Selection

## UPDATED SQUAD:

Shubman Gill (Captain), KL Rahul (Vice-Captain), Yashasvi Jaiswal, Rishabh Pant (WK), Dhruv Jurel (WK), Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav, Manav Suthar, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Devdutt Padikkal, Saransh Jain, Aaquib Nabi, Sarfaraz Khan.

Committee has named Sarfaraz Khan as a replacement for Sai Sudharsan for the two-match Test series against Sri Lanka," BCCI said in a release. "He will link up with the Indian squad in Colombo

before the team travels to Galle for the first Test match, starting August 15, 2026." The 28-year-old Sarfaraz has played six Tests for India, his last being a game against New Zealand in Mumbai in 2024. AGENCIES

# Shahnavaz wins long jump bronze

Meghwal creates history with high jump silver

EUGENE: Basant Kumar Meghwal and Shahnavaz Khan became the first Indians to win a medal each in high jump and long jump at the World Athletics U20 Championships, clinching a silver and a bronze in their respective events on a memorable day for the country here.

The 19-year-old Basant, the reigning Asian U20 champion, cleared a personal-best of 2.21m to win the silver in the men's high jump, while Shahnavaz clinched the bronze in the men's long jump event with a best effort of 7.84m.

Algeria's Younes Ayachi won the gold, while Great Britain's Otis Poole took the bronze. All the three medalists could only clear 2.21m but failed all their three attempts to sail over 2.24m. The positions were thus decided on count-back based on the number of attempts to clear the previous height.

Ayachi cleared 2.21m in his first jump, while Meghwal and Poole did the same in their second and third attempts respectively. Coached by former Indian women's high jump national record holder Sahana Kumari, Basant has made a remarkable 10cm improvement this season, raising his personal best from 2.11m to 2.21m. He won gold in the National Junior Fed Cup in 2025 and 2026, before bagging the Asian U20 Championships title in May this year.

Basant, currently employed with the Indian Navy, hails from village 12 A-B near the border town of Anupgarh in Sri Ganganagar district in Rajasthan. Villages in border areas of Rajasthan are named using colonial-era irrigation block numbering system. His farmer father Gangaram Meghwal, who also doubles up as driver and daily wage labourer, was



Shahnavaz Khan

the main driving force for Basant to take up sports.

India's medal tally then rose to three at the championships after Shahnavaz clinched a bronze in the men's long jump with a best effort of 7.84m.

The 18-year-old produced his best jump in his third attempt, with his series reading 7.67m, 7.72m, 7.84m, 7.52m, 7.83m and 5.37m.

Jithin Arjunan was the other Indian in the final, finishing eighth with a best jump of 7.59m. Italy's Daniele Inzoli won the gold medal with a jump of 7.97m, while Australia's Mason McGroder took silver with a personal best of 7.96m.

The 18-year-old Shahnavaz is one of the most promising long jumpers in the country

with Commonwealth Games silver medalist Murali Sreesankar showering high praise on the youngster. He is the current national U20 record holder (8.30m) and reigning Asian U20 champion.

He is currently third in the Asian senior top list of the season with his 8.30m jump while finishing behind Sreesankar (8.38m) at the National Interstate Championships in June. He won gold at the Asian U20 Championships in May with a jump of 7.84m.

In the last four months, he has improved his personal best from 8.23m to 8.30m. At such a young age, his personal best (8.30m) is the all-time third among the Indians (seniors) behind Jeswin Aldrin (8.42m) and Sreesankar (8.41m). AGENCIES

# Kuldeep took break to assess body, not fitness concern: Sairaj Bahutule

COLOMBO: Kuldeep Yadav did not bowl in the second innings of the warm-up game against Sri Lanka Cricket XI as he wanted to assess his body after a heavy workload, India's spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule said on Sunday, allaying concerns over the left-arm wrist-spinner's fitness.

Kuldeep bowled 18 overs in the three-day game after also putting in two-three overs before the match, and Bahutule said the decision to rest him was purely precautionary.

"Kuldeep bowled almost 20 overs in the sense 18 in the match and about two-three overs before the game also. He had a very good outing and he just wanted to take a break in terms of just understanding how his body is at," Bahutule said after the warm-up game here.

The other spinners -- Ravindra Jadeja, Manav Suthar and Saransh Jain -- were given extended outings as India used the game to assess their options



India's Kuldeep Yadav

ahead of the first Test against Sri Lanka in Galle.

"Manav bowled about 14-15 overs, Jaddu bowled about 14-15 overs. So, they got a very good outing, they understood how the pitch reacts and I think it was a great prep for them," he said.

The pitch offered little assistance to the spinners initially but began to turn as the game progressed, providing valuable exposure to India's slow bowlers.

"The bowlers had a great opportunity to go down and express themselves on a pitch which was slightly on a flatter side in the first day. But as the days went by, there was more turn on it and definitely a good outing for the spinners," Bahutule said.

India had fielded a strong squad for the warm-up game with the primary objective of adapting to local conditions, and Bahutule felt the players made the most of the opportunity.

"Most of the guys have come here, experienced guys, Jaddu has already played here. But the new guys like Manav and a few others, Saransh Jain, they need to just adapt to what will be the ideal lines, what will be the ideal lengths and obviously the field sets, which is very much important."

India's management was also satisfied with Shubman Gill's recovery after he was hit on his right hand during a net session on Thursday. AGENCIES

# Sher-e-Punjab T20: Sanvir Singh joins Gill's Fazilka Falcons

Naman Dhir was bought by Amritsar Soormas for Rs 10.80 lakh

CHANDIGARH: All-rounder Sanvir Singh emerged as the highest pick in the first half of the auction for the upcoming season of the Sher-e-Punjab T20 League, with Fazilka Falcons securing the player for Rs 13.20 lakh.

Sanvir will now have the opportunity to represent Fazilka Falcons alongside marquee player and Indian cricket team captain Shubman Gill.

President of the Punjab Cricket Association (PCA) Amarjit Singh Mehta said, "We have worked very hard alongside our Punjab chief minister to turn this dream into reality, and it is now close to being

fulfilled.

"Every cricketer dreams of playing at the PCA Stadium in Mohali, and through this league, players from across Punjab will get the opportunity to play at this iconic venue, gain valuable exposure and showcase their talent on a bigger platform."

Among the other major picks, Naman Dhir was bought by Amritsar Soormas for Rs 10.80 lakh, while Amolpreet Singh joined Mohali Kings for Rs 8.20 lakh.

Harnoor Singh and Ashwani Kumar were both picked by Bathinda

Royals for Rs 7 lakh each, while Sukhdeep Bajwa was acquired by Jalandhar Warriors for Rs 6 lakh.

Harpreet Brar was picked by Mohali Kings for Rs 4 lakh, while Mayank Markande joined Amritsar Soormas for Rs 1.50 lakh.

PCA Secretary Gurmeet Singh Meht Hayer said, "The first half of the auction has reflected the tremendous depth of cricketing talent in Punjab. The franchises have shown great enthusiasm in identifying and investing in players who have the potential to make a mark at the highest level. AGENCIES

## PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Mohd. Israil, S/o Abbu Mohammad, R/o 1) H.No. 9062/1, Ram Bagh, Azad Market, Delhi, 2) Village Khakhara, Sitalrampur, Bihar has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case E-FIR No. 128/2020, U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Subzi Mandi, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Mohd. Israil cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Mohd. Israil has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said Mohd. Israil accused of E-FIR No. 128/2020, U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Subzi Mandi, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 10.09.2026.

By Order - Ms. Preeti Rajoria  
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07  
DP/11030/N/2026 Room No. 32, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

**Office of the Commandant 25<sup>th</sup> Battalion SAF, Bhopal//**  
No.-25<sup>th</sup> Bn/Petrolpump/3089/2026, Dated: 07.08.2026

**INVITING TENDER FOR SILENT DIESEL GENERATOR SET**

Bid proposals are invited from reputed manufactures & venders for the supply, installation and commissioning of following item at police petrol pump operational at 25<sup>th</sup> Battalion SAF, Bhadbadha road, Bhopal.

| S.No. | Name of Item                                                                          | Approximate amount | Earnest Money Deposit | Cost of Bid Document | Period of Contract |
|-------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|-----------------------|----------------------|--------------------|
| 1.    | Supply, Installation & Commissioning of 25 kVA Silent Diesel Generator with AMF PANEL | 5,25,000/-         | 16,000/-              | 2000/-               | 14 Days            |

//Interested bidders can view the MP Tender Portal on website <https://mptenders.gov.in/> & MP Police Portal on website <https://www.mppolice.gov.in/en/tenders>.

- The Bid Document can be downloaded only online from 10:00 AM (time) (date) 08/08/2026 to 16:00 (time) (date) 22/08/2026
- Bid schedule: -  
Start date of bid submission: - 10:00 AM (time) (date) 08.08.2026  
Last date of bid submission: - 16:00 PM (time) (date) 22.08.2026  
Technical bid Opening - 16:30 PM (time) (date) 24.08.2026
- Amendments to NIT, if any, would be published on website <https://mptenders.gov.in> 02 national, 02 state level and 02 local newspaper and <https://www.mppolice.gov.in/en/tenders>

G16911/26

COMMANDANT  
25th Battalion, S.A.F.  
Bhopal

"स्वभाव स्वकर्ता, संस्कार स्वकर्ता"





## ‘HONoured TO BE A PART OF TOXIC’

Huma Qureshi said she has been getting a lot of questions about the film

NEW DELHI: Huma Qureshi is honoured to be a part of ‘Toxic: A Fairytale for Grown-Ups’. The film is directed by Geetu Mohandas and will feature the actor in the role of Elizabeth alongside Yash. Qureshi said she has been getting a lot of questions about the film.

“The love that I’ve been getting since the time I signed this film has just been incredible. Whenever I go anywhere and I’ve met so many of you members of the media and press for the last year, the

one single thing that everyone asks me all the time is about ‘Toxic’. And whether I say something or not, I think you guys just make it go viral. That is the power of this film,” she said.

She added, “Geetu, you have been such an amazing chapter, giving us all. And every time I get asked about my character, I’m like, ‘Wait, I can’t tell you too much. You have to watch the film’. And the film will speak for itself. I’m just honoured to be part of it. Thank you, Yash. You have been incredible. I have learnt so much from you every single day. I’m just so excited to watch the film already. Can we just release it now?”

‘The love that I’ve been getting since the time I signed this film has just been incredible,’ she says

The film also features Nayanthara, Kiara Advani, Rukmini Vasanth, Tara Sutaria and others and



unfolds in Goa between the early 1940s and the 1970s. In the film, the ‘KGF’ star plays the role of Raya, a gangster.

It is produced by ‘KVN Productions’ and Yash’s ‘Monster Mind Creations’. The film is shot in Kannada and English and will also be released in dubbed versions in Hindi, Tamil and Telugu languages. PTI

## Dwayne responds to Moana’s mixed reviews

Johnson said he isn’t bothered by the mixed reviews on his latest film



LOS ANGELES: Dwayne Johnson said he isn’t bothered by the mixed reviews on his latest film ‘Moana’. The actor essayed the role of Maui in the film, which was released in July. It was directed by Thomas Kail and starred Catherine Laga’aia in the role of Moana. The film earned over 264 million dollars at the box office and had mixed responses from the audience.

“Our first two reviews came out... I’ll never forget it... They were amazing. I was like, ‘Wow...’. Then it went another way. That’s just the way it goes because we’re in this business,” the actor told entertainment news magazine ‘People’ in an interview. He added, “The challenge was,

The Hollywood actor essayed the role of Maui in the film

“Okay, let’s remember, though, what’s going to be beyond this opening weekend... Let’s remember what’s happening right now and the noise that’s happening right now... If you love it, great. If you don’t, no problem. What mattered was the culture stood up.”

The ‘Disney’ film revolves around a brave teenager from a Polynesian island who sails across the ocean to find a demigod and save her starving people. It also starred Frankie, Rena Owen and John Tui, among others. PTI

## AN EMOTIONALLY-DRIVEN GANGSTER SAGA

### It’s Yash vs Yash in ‘Toxic’ trailer

The multi-starrer will be released on August 26

#### OUR CORRESPONDENT

The much-awaited trailer of ‘Toxic: A Fairytale for Grown-Ups’ is out, offering a first glimpse into a sprawling world where chaos meets chaos, loyalties are tested and every character carries a story of their own.

Headlined by Rocking Star Yash, the trailer presents ‘Toxic’ as a larger-than-life magnum opus combining high-octane action and scale with an emotionally charged narrative rooted in love, hunger for power, betrayal and redemption. From striking visuals and explosive action to layered characters and intense relationships, the trailer promises a gangster saga that is as emotionally



driven as it is spectacular.

At the heart of ‘Toxic’ lies the complex relationship between Raya and his son, Ticket, adding an emotional core to the larger-than-life gangster world. The trailer also introduces a web of relationships and rivalries, with glimpses into the character arc of Nayanthara, Kiara Advani, Tara Sutaria, Ruk-

mini Vasanth and Huma Qureshi. The ensemble makes a strong impression, with each actor bringing distinct shades and intensity to their characters.

Director Geetu Mohandas brings her distinctive storytelling and visual sensibility to ‘Toxic’, creating an immersive and unpredictable world. The trailer sets up a Yash vs



The film has five leading actresses, namely Nayanthara, Kiara Advani, Tara Sutaria, Rukmini Vasanth and Huma Qureshi

Yash face-off, with Yash portraying both Raya and Ticket - a father and son on opposite sides of an explosive conflict. Beyond this central battle, the trailer showcases the film’s ambitious world-

building through high-octane action, thrilling sequences, striking production design and atmospheric visuals. The cinematography further enhances its dark, textured and visually arresting world, while Geetu brings together action, emotion and intricate character dynamics into an ambitious cinematic experience.

Shot in English and Kannada, ‘Toxic’ will also be released in dubbed versions in Hindi, Telugu, Tamil and Malayalam on August 26.

## Richa, Ali to feature in ‘Conan O’Brien Must Go’ S3

The series will release on HBO on August 21

NEW DELHI: Richa Chadha and Ali Fazal are set to feature in Conan O’Brien’s series ‘Conan O’Brien Must Go Season 3’.

As part of Conan’s journey through India, the duo will join him for a conversation blended with his signature wit. Filled with playful banter, cultural observations and plenty of laughs, the segment promises to offer audiences an entertaining glimpse into India through Conan’s unmistakable comedic lens, according to a press release.

Chadha and Fazal said the conversation they had with O’Brien was ‘unfiltered, spontaneous and filled with humour’. “Conan O’Brien is quite simply a legend. We’ve admired his unique brand of humour for years, so getting to sit across from him and be a part of his India journey was surreal



As part of Conan’s journey through India, the duo will join him for a conversation blended with his signature wit

in the best way,” they said in a joint statement.

“The conversation was completely unfiltered, spontaneous and with the kind of humour that only Conan can bring out. We had an absolute blast filming it and can’t wait for audiences

around the world to see this wonderfully chaotic exchange,” they added.

The series will release on HBO on August 21 and will follow O’Brien visiting India, the Netherlands, Morocco and the Philippines. PTI



## First Look: Mahesh Babu in ‘Varanasi’

NEW DELHI: The makers of ‘Varanasi’ unveiled the first look poster of Mahesh Babu, who is set to essay the role of Rudhra in the film.

The film is directed by S S Rajamouli and also features Priyanka Chopra and Prithviraj Sukumaran alongside the actor. It is to be released on April 7, 2027 and revolves around a community in 512 AD who possess an ancient secret that can save the world.

In 2027 AD, an asteroid named Shambhavi collides

The actor is set to essay the role of Rudhra in S S Rajamouli’s film

with Earth, causing a cataclysmic event. Meanwhile, a greedy scientist, Kumbha (Prithviraj), becomes paralysed while trying to retrieve the artefact, reads the logline of the film.

The poster was shared by

the ‘RRR’ filmmaker on his X handle on Sunday and featured the actor reclining on a bamboo raft in a jungle setting. The following post featured him against the backdrop of Africa. “Fierce isn’t his only shade... RUDHRA in #Varanasi. @urstrulyMahesh,” read the caption.

‘Varanasi’ will feature music by MM Keeravani, who won an Oscar for Rajamouli’s previous film ‘RRR’. It is produced by ‘Sri Durga Arts’ and ‘Showing Business’. PTI

## ‘POLITICS EXISTS & IT WILL ALWAYS GO ON’

About film ‘Satluj’, Jimmy said that stirred sensitive issues brings everything into open

MUMBAI: Jimmy Shergill said films attempting to portray politically sensitive periods of history often run into trouble as they bring out hidden truths and things naturally become complicated and political.

The actor responded to a query on why a film like ‘Satluj’, which dealt with a sensitive subject, didn’t see a release while his own debut, ‘Maachis’, dealing with a similar theme, was appreciated.

‘Satluj’, starring actor-singer Diljit Dosanjh, released in India last month on streaming service ‘Zee5’, but became unavailable on the platform just two days later in India. The film, based on the life of human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khaira, was stuck in censorship for over three years and

was given over 127 cuts by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC).

“Politics exists and it will always go on. But it is good when such issues are stirred up because it brings every single aspect out into the open. When you touch upon even a single aspect of sensitive matters, other hidden aspects



surface as well. So, that is the politics of it,” Shergill told PTI.

On the other side, ‘Maachis’, which was directed by Gulzar, was set against the turbulent period of insurgency in Punjab during the 1980s. Also starring Chandrachur Singh, Om Puri and Tabu, the political thriller explores the personal and political turmoil faced by people caught in violence. Upon its release, it received critical acclaim and was a commercial hit too. At the 44th National Film Awards, the film won two honours, including ‘Best Popular Film Providing Wholesome Entertainment’ and the ‘Best Actress’ award for Tabu. PTI

